

Inflation, Households, and Central Banks Around the World *

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Abstract

Which facts about households’ inflation expectations arise universally across countries and demographic groups? Using homogeneous survey data from 32,000 respondents in 32 countries, we document substantial heterogeneity in perceived and expected inflation across demographic groups and countries but similarity in expectation formation processes. Older, male, and economically literate respondents have lower perceptions and expectations. The opposite holds for unemployed and impatient respondents. Yet, the mapping of perceived into expected inflation is similar across demographic groups, countries, and inflation-targeting regimes. In contrast, inflation narratives vary sharply across countries: Europeans stress geopolitical shocks and supply disruptions, while respondents in high-inflation countries attribute inflation to central banks. Support for non-standard central-bank mandates, such as environmental objectives and inequality reduction, also differ systematically across demographic groups and countries. This variation matters because respondents whose desired central bank mandates diverge from those they think central banks pursue have higher inflation expectations and lower trust in central banks.

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1 Introduction

Modern monetary policy relies on the premise that central banks can influence agents’ inflation expectations through policy actions and communication. Despite mounting research documenting deviations from the traditional benchmark of full information rational expectations (FIRE), the drivers of households’ heterogeneous inflation expectations and of the processes households use to form such expectations remain elusive (D’Acunto and Weber, 2024). Existing evidence is mostly based on ad-hoc surveys that use different methods, wordings, and concepts to elicit inflation expectations and are conducted at different points in the inflation cycle (Weber et al., 2022), complicating the identification of common drivers of inflation expectations that are consistent across economic agents.

To overcome these limitations and identify universal drivers of inflation expectations, this paper proposes evidence based on harmonized household survey data from 32 countries from the second wave of the Global Survey of Economic Perceptions and Expectations, fielded in March and April 2025 among approximately 32,000 respondents across 32 advanced and emerging economies.¹ The survey elicits inflation perceptions and expectations, narratives about the causes of inflation, knowledge of central banks, perceived and desired central-bank objectives, and institutional trust with identical questions across countries.

Our evidence yields four main results. First, a set of demographic correlates of inflation perceptions and expectations arise universally around the globe. Older respondents, men, respondents who recognize the name of their central bank, and those who understand the effects of inflation on nominal savings report lower past inflation perceptions and future inflation expectations. Unemployed and more impatient respondents report higher values. Crucially, the same correlates arise for both perceptions and expectations, both in sign and magnitude.

¹The first wave was introduced by D’Acunto and Weber (2025) to assess parsimonious adaptations of standard rational inattention models of belief formation to realistically capture facts about households’ expectations, including the systematic upward bias detected around the globe. Their evidence suggests that variation in the representativeness of the economic signals households obtain from different information sources for the distribution of aggregate inflation is key to rationalize such systematic facts in standard rational inattention settings.

Second, despite broad differences in the levels of inflation perceptions and expectations, the mapping from perceived past inflation into expected future inflation is remarkably stable across demographic groups and institutional settings. The relationship is nearly identical by gender, education levels, impatience, central-bank knowledge, inflation knowledge, and trust in the central bank. It is also similar across geographic regions, countries with different inflation histories, and countries with point inflation targets rather than target ranges. Overall, households appear to differ substantially in the inflation they perceive and hence expect, but conditional on these perceptions, they form their expectations in similar ways. This evidence suggests that understanding what drives demographic heterogeneity in inflation perceptions is key ([D’Acunto et al., 2021](#)).

Third, households differ systematically in the causal narratives they associate with the post-pandemic inflation surge. European respondents are substantially more likely to attribute inflation to wars and geopolitical conflict, whereas respondents in countries with histories of very high inflation are more likely to attribute it to central-bank policy. Causal narratives also vary economically and statistically with individual characteristics including age, employment status, political alignment, and knowledge of inflation and central banks. The universal mapping of inflation perceptions into expectations coexists with substantial heterogeneity in the subjective explanations households use to interpret inflation.

Fourth, we consider households’ desired central-bank mandates. We find that price and financial stability receive broad support, but many respondents also want central banks to pursue broader objectives, including fostering economic growth, inequality reduction, environmental goals, and credit provision to households. Respondents with greater knowledge of inflation and central banks place more weight on standard central-bank objectives, whereas women and younger respondents are more likely to support broader mandates. Geographic differences are also pronounced. Relative to respondents in the Middle East and Africa, European households are less likely to favor exchange-rate stability, economic growth, environmental protection, and inequality reduction as central-bank objectives. Respondents in English-speaking countries are similarly less likely to support exchange-rate stability and environmental protection, whereas

South American respondents are less likely to favor credit provision to governments.

Why should we care about respondents’ desired central bank mandates, given that central banks, unlike legislatures and governments, are not elected by the general public, and that households’ desired mandates do not directly enter standard models of expectation formation? We find that respondents have higher inflation expectations and lower trust in the central bank when the objectives they want it to pursue differ from those they believe it actually pursues. These associations remain after absorbing demographic heterogeneity and country fixed effects, suggesting that disagreement about the scope of central-bank responsibilities might be closely related to perceived institutional credibility and to the perceived effectiveness of monetary policy.

Overall, our findings inform the ongoing debate in monetary economics about the drivers of consumers’ inflation expectations, their formation and updating processes, and the causes and consequences of heterogeneous inflation expectations. The paper connects several strands of literature. First, we contribute to the literature on the formation and heterogeneity of households’ inflation expectations. Existing work documents systematic differences in beliefs by gender ([Jonung, 1981](#); [Ehrmann et al., 2017](#); [D’Acunto et al., 2021](#)), income ([Bryan and Venkatu, 2001](#); [Das et al., 2020](#)), cognitive ability and financial literacy ([De Bruin et al., 2010](#); [Burke and Manz, 2014](#); [D’Acunto et al., 2022](#)), and exposure to salient prices ([Coibion and Gorodnichenko, 2015](#); [Cavallo et al., 2017](#); [D’Acunto et al., 2021](#); [Binder and Makridis, 2022](#)). A complementary literature explains disagreement and sluggish adjustment through the infrequent acquisition or diffusion of information and limited attention ([Mankiw and Reis, 2002](#); [Carroll, 2003](#); [Sims, 2003](#); [Mankiw et al., 2003](#)). Most empirical evidence, however, is based on individual countries or on surveys that are not designed to be comparable across countries. Recent evidence from the ECB Consumer Expectations Survey confirms that substantial heterogeneity remains within and across European countries even after conditioning on demographic characteristics ([Dräger, Marenčák, Nghiem, and Paloviita, Dräger et al.](#)). Our harmonized survey allows us to assess which demographic correlates of inflation beliefs generalize across economic and institutional environments. It also allows us to distinguish

heterogeneity in the levels of perceived and expected inflation from heterogeneity in the mapping between them. The stability of this mapping across demographic groups and countries suggests that differences in expectations arise primarily from heterogeneous inflation perceptions rather than from systematically different expectation-formation processes—a direction that should be further explored in the literature also due to its implications for informing macroeconomic theory.²

Second, our findings relate to the growing literature on subjective models of the economy and economic narratives. This work shows that households hold heterogeneous causal views of the macroeconomy, that these views often differ from those of experts, and that they shape both expectations and the interpretation of new information (Svenson and Nilsson, 1986; Shiller, 2020; Andre et al., 2022, 2026; Binetti et al., 2024; Dräger et al., 2025; D’Acunto et al., 2025). Related evidence shows that information conveyed through stories can have more persistent effects on beliefs than statistical information because stories are more readily recalled (Graeber et al., 2024). Existing studies typically focus on a single country or economic episode. We provide comparable evidence across 32 countries and show that inflation narratives vary systematically across regions and with countries’ inflation histories. Hence, heterogeneity in narratives does not arise solely across individuals within a common environment. The historical, geographic, and institutional environment is also systematically related to the causal accounts households use to interpret inflation.

Third, our results contribute to the literature on central-bank credibility, communication, and public trust (Blinder, 2000; Woodford, 2005; Dräger, 2015; Ehrmann and Wabitsch, 2022; D’Acunto et al., 2020; Christelis et al., 2020; Kuang et al., 2024, 2025). Previous work studies how knowledge of central banks relates to trust (Ehrmann et al., 2013; Hayo and Neuenkirch, 2014), how central banks can communicate with non-expert audiences (Haldane and McMahon, 2018; Blinder et al., 2023), and whether communication affects households’ inflation expectations (Coibion et al., 2022). This literature generally focuses on whether households know

²Recent reviews of this literature include Weber et al. (2022, 2023); D’Acunto et al. (2023); D’Acunto and Weber (2024); Dräger and Lamla (2024); D’Acunto et al. (2024); D’Acunto and Weber (2025).

and trust the central bank and whether they respond to its messages. We study a separate dimension: whether the objectives households believe their central bank pursues coincide with the objectives they want it to pursue. The gap between perceived and desired mandates is systematically associated with higher inflation expectations and lower trust, conditional on individual characteristics and country fixed effects. Our results therefore suggest that central-bank credibility is related not only to policy performance, knowledge, and the effectiveness of communication, but also to whether households agree with the appropriate scope of central-bank responsibilities.

2 Global Survey of Economic Perceptions and Expectations

Our analysis is based on the second wave of the Global Survey of Economic Perceptions and Expectations, which measures households’ macroeconomic perceptions, expectations, knowledge, and attitudes using a common survey instrument across countries. The first survey wave was fielded in April 2023 and is described in detail in [D’Acunto and Weber \(2025\)](#).

The second wave was fielded in March and April 2025 and includes 32,462 respondents across 32 advanced economies and emerging market economies. In each country, we surveyed approximately 1,000 respondents between 18 and 70 years of age. The country samples were constructed to match the age and gender composition of the corresponding populations. The survey company Cint translated a common English-language questionnaire into the relevant national languages, which limits differences in elicitation across countries. Respondents were informed that the survey would take approximately 8–10 minutes and that there were no right or wrong answers. At the beginning of the questionnaire, we included an instructional attention check and retained only respondents who followed the stated instructions.

The survey consists of 30 questions grouped into four parts. The first part focuses on households’ near-term macroeconomic perceptions and expectations. Following standard practice in

the literature ([Armantier et al., 2013](#); [Weber et al., 2022](#)), respondents first receive a short definition of inflation and a numerical example illustrating positive, negative, and zero inflation. They then report their perception of inflation over the previous 12 months and their expectations for inflation over the subsequent 12 months. Following [Guiso et al. \(2002\)](#); [Coibion et al. \(2024\)](#), respondents provide the lowest, highest, and most likely values they assign to future inflation. This elicitation allows us to construct measures of the first and second moments of respondents’ subjective distributions under standard distributional assumptions while imposing relatively limited cognitive demands. We also ask which prices respondents had in mind when reporting their inflation beliefs, allowing them to select groceries, rent, gasoline and other energy prices, clothing, electronics and appliances, education, other goods, or no specific prices ([D’Acunto et al., 2021](#); [D’Acunto and Weber, 2025](#)).

This part also elicits expectations about household income, unemployment, and interest rates over the next 12 months. For each variable, respondents indicate whether they expect an increase, a decrease, or approximately no change and, when applicable, report the expected percent change. In the empirical analysis, we use indicators that equal one when a respondent expects the corresponding variable to increase and zero otherwise. We adopt this coding because a large share of respondents selects the no-change category, whereas a small number report large numerical increases or decreases, producing highly non-linear response distributions. Finally, respondents report how much they trust their country’s central bank, government, and banks and financial institutions to act in their best interest. Trust is measured on a four-point scale ranging from “not at all” to “a lot,” and the order of the institutions is randomized.

The second part of the survey studies households’ views of the inflation surge and contrasts the period from 2020 to 2024 with the five years preceding the pandemic. Respondents report their perceived cumulative changes in consumer prices and in the incomes of people like them over 2015–2019 and 2020–2024. To facilitate comparability, the questionnaire asks respondents to think about the cost of a consumption bundle representing everyday purchases and provides a numerical example of how to calculate a percentage change over a multiyear period. We then elicit respondents’ narratives about the post-pandemic inflation surge. Respondents can

attribute the rise in prices to the government, the central bank, commodity prices, firms' pursuit of higher profits, pandemic-related shortages, wars, and higher wages, with the order of the alternatives randomized and multiple selections allowed. An analogous question asks respondents which factors contributed to changes in their household income. The module concludes by asking whether respondents can afford more or fewer goods and services than in 2020 on a five-point scale ranging from "way less" to "way more."

The third part assesses households' knowledge and perceptions of central banks. Respondents first identify their country's central bank from a randomized list of institutions, which provides an objective measure of central-bank awareness. We then present the same randomized list of nine potential central-bank objectives twice. Respondents first select the objectives they believe their central bank currently pursues and then the objectives they would like it to pursue. The list includes price stability, financial stability, exchange-rate stability, economic growth, environmental goals, inequality reduction, credit provision to the government, credit provision to private banks, and credit provision to households and firms. Respondents can select multiple objectives in each question. The common set of alternatives allows us to construct, for each respondent, a direct measure of the gap between perceived and desired central-bank mandates. Additional questions assess whether respondents understand the instruments through which central banks operate, whether they support central-bank independence from the government, and which sources they use to obtain information about central banks and monetary policy. The information sources include traditional media, social media, the central bank's website, banks and financial advisers, and personal contacts.

The final part collects respondents' demographic, socioeconomic, and attitudinal characteristics. We measure respondents' understanding of inflation using an objective question about whether a nominal return on savings necessarily raises purchasing power irrespective of inflation following [Lusardi and Mitchell \(2014\)](#). We also elicit the monthly frequency of grocery shopping and gasoline purchases, which proxy for exposure to salient prices following [D'Acunto et al. \(2021\)](#); [D'Acunto et al. \(2021\)](#); [D'Acunto and Weber \(2025\)](#). Respondents assess their willingness to take financial risks, mathematical ability, and impatience on ordered scales. The

remaining variables include household income in local currency, home ownership and mortgage status, employment status, household size, education, whether respondents hold a degree in business, finance, or economics, and whether the political party closest to their views was part of the national government at the time of the survey.

2.1 Summary Statistics

We report detailed definitions of the demographic variables we use in the empirical analysis in Table A.1 of the Online Appendix, while Table 1 reports summary statistics for the pooled sample. Because each country contributes approximately the same number of respondents, these moments give roughly equal weight to the countries in our sample and should not be interpreted as population-weighted global averages.

Throughout the analysis, we winsorize inflation perception and expectations at the 1-99% levels to reduce the influence of outliers. Respondents perceive inflation over the previous 12 months to have been 16.7% on average and expect inflation over the subsequent 12 months to be 15.1%. The corresponding medians are 10% and 9%, respectively. Thus, both the mean and the median respondent expect inflation to decline relative to their perception of recent inflation. The large differences between the means and medians, together with standard deviations of 22.8% and 19.8%, indicate that both distributions are strongly right-skewed. Responses also display substantial heaping: 8% of respondents report expected inflation of exactly 5%, and 13% report exactly 10%, consistent with the rounding commonly observed in household inflation surveys (Binder, 2017).

Expectations about other macroeconomic outcomes are less dispersed when expressed as directional indicators. 19% of respondents expect interest rates to increase over the next 12 months, while 26% expect unemployment to increase and 26% expect their household income to increase. These variables capture the direction rather than the magnitude of expected changes and are therefore not directly comparable with the numerical inflation measures.

The average respondent is 40.9 years old, and women account for 49% of the sample. 60%

of respondents correctly identify their country’s central bank, while 64% correctly answer the question about the effect of inflation on the purchasing power of nominal savings. The latter variable measures a specific dimension of respondents’ understanding of inflation and is one of the big three questions on financial literacy (Lusardi and Mitchell, 2023). Respondents report average risk tolerance of 3.09, self-assessed mathematical ability of 3.70, and impatience of 2.84 on five-point scales. The effective sample sizes for these measures differ slightly because of item non-response.

Among respondents who report a political preference, 56% state that their preferred party was part of the national government at the time of the survey. The number of observations for this variable is lower because some respondents do not identify a preferred party or do not answer the question. We therefore do not interpret the unconditional share as evidence that the sample is disproportionately aligned with incumbent governments.

The final rows of Table 1 report trust in the central bank, the government, and domestic banks and financial institutions. All three variables are measured on a four-point scale. Average trust is highest for central banks at 2.72, followed by banks and financial institutions at 2.62 and governments at 2.51. The median is three for all three institutions, indicating that the average differences are modest relative to the dispersion of trust within the sample.

The statistics so far refer to demographic characteristics and their distribution in the full global sample. In the the paper, we also aim to assess the heterogeneity in inflation perceptions and expectations, the causes of inflation, and central bank mandates across space by comparing a set of country groups. To organize this analysis, we split the countries in our sample into six groups that collect geographically and/or economically close countries: Asia, Middle East and Africa, English-speaking countries (Anglo-Saxon), South America (excluding Argentina), Europe, and High Inflation countries (Argentina, Turkey, and Russia).³ We report the constituting countries of each group in Table A.2 of the Online Appendix.

³To define High Inflation countries, we selected the countries whose average year-to-year inflation rate in March and April 2025 was above 10%. This selection criterion leads us to isolate Argentina (51.6%), Turkey (38%), and Russia (10.3%). Note that the highest-inflation country that does not make this threshold is Brazil (5.5%)

In terms of descriptive statistics, we plot the distribution of inflation perceptions and expectations across these six country groups in Figure A.1 of the Online Appendix. The figure documents a few properties. First, the right tail of large and positive inflation perceptions and expectations is present across all the country groups we consider. Second, despite a generalized mass of high inflation perceptions and expectations, the dispersion of both variables varies systematically across country groups: households in European and Anglo-Saxon countries display the least dispersion and cross-sectional variation in both perceptions and beliefs, while both variables are substantially more dispersed for households in South America, Asia, and EMEA countries. Moreover, and perhaps unsurprisingly, dispersion is substantially larger in High Inflation countries. What’s more surprising about High inflation countries is that both distributions are closer to uniform than for other country groups: High Inflation countries include households who have inflation perceptions and expectations that are in line with the realizations in advanced economies as well as sizable fractions of the sample that expect values at any positive level, including up to 100%. High inflation countries also include substantial fraction of households that report rounded values for both inflation perceptions and expectations at multiples of 5%, which appear to be a larger proportion of all reported values relative to what we observe for the other country groups.

3 Households’ Inflation Perceptions and Expectations Around the World

This section leverages the global setting to revisit several stylized facts from the previous literature to study whether they are a robust finding globally or are contained to selected surveys, in selected countries, or during selected periods of time.

3.1 Demographics and Views About Inflation

We first study whether individual characteristics that have been associated with inflation expectations in specific countries also predict expectations in a common survey conducted across a broad set of economic and institutional environments. Establishing such common correlates is useful for two reasons. First, it indicates which sources of heterogeneity are not specific to a particular survey design or inflation episode. Second, it provides a natural starting point for assessing whether demographic differences arise from the inflation rates households perceive or from the way in which they map those perceptions into expectations.

Table 2 reports estimates from specifications of the following form:

$$\text{Inflation Expectations}_{i,c} = \alpha + \mathbf{X}'_{i,c} \delta + \varepsilon_{i,c}, \quad (1)$$

where $\text{Inflation Expectations}_{i,c}$ are the 12-month-ahead numerical inflation expectations reported by respondent i in country c , and $\mathbf{X}_{i,c}$ includes, in separate columns, each of the individual-level demographic variables described in the survey. Standard errors are clustered at the country level.

Several individual characteristics are associated with economically meaningful differences in inflation expectations. In the multivariate specification, the coefficient on age is -0.101 , implying that a respondent who is 20 years older reports inflation expectations about 2 percentage points (pp) lower. Women report expectations 2.6 pp higher than men, a difference equal to about 17% of the sample mean. This gender gap is similar in magnitude to estimates from individual countries (Jonung, 1981; Ehrmann et al., 2017; D’Acunto et al., 2021). High-impatience respondents report expectations 3.1 pp higher than otherwise similar respondents, consistent with single-country evidence that impatience and present bias are associated with higher and less accurate inflation beliefs (D’Acunto et al., 2022).

Knowledge of inflation and monetary institutions is also associated with differences of comparable magnitude. Respondents who correctly identify their country’s central bank report inflation expectations 2.5 pp lower, while those who understand the effect of inflation on the

purchasing power of nominal savings report expectations about 3.1 percentage points lower. These associations are economically large relative to the sample mean and remain present after controlling for income, education, employment, and other respondent characteristics. The contrast between the insignificant coefficient on college education and the large coefficients on the two knowledge measures is informative. General educational attainment appears to not add any predictability of the cross section of inflation expectations above and beyond knowledge that is directly relevant for understanding inflation and monetary policy. These correlations do not establish that knowledge lowers inflation expectations, because respondents who acquire economic information may differ along unobserved dimensions, but they are consistent with better-informed households holding more moderate inflation expectations.

Other demographic characteristics that earlier work based on single-country evidence found to be correlated with inflation expectations are less relevant to help us understand the cross-section of beliefs in a global setting. Unemployed respondents report expectations 2.4 pp higher in the univariate specification, but the coefficient declines to 1.9 pp and is no longer statistically significant once the remaining characteristics are included. Similarly, single respondents report lower expectations, although the multivariate estimate is only marginally significant. Income, college education, renter status, risk tolerance, political alignment, and trust in the central bank are not independently associated with expectations at conventional significance levels.

To assess the extent to which these demographic differences originate in households' perceptions of recent inflation (rather than in demographic-specific processes to map inflation perceptions into expectations), Table 3 repeats the analysis using perceived inflation over the previous 12 months as the dependent variable.

The results closely resemble those for expectations. A 20-year age difference is associated with perceived inflation about 2 pp lower; women report perceptions 2.2 pp higher; and high-impatience respondents report perceptions approximately 4 pp higher. Respondents who identify their central bank or understand the effect of inflation on nominal savings also report substantially lower perceptions.

The close correspondence between Tables 2 and 3 suggests that demographic heterogene-

ity in expected inflation may originate primarily in different assessments of recent inflation rather than different belief-formation processes (Jonung, 1981; D’Acunto et al., 2021). The next subsection examines this interpretation directly by studying whether the mapping from perceptions into expectations differs across groups.

3.2 Inflation Expectations and Perceptions Across Country Groups

We turn to consider how average inflation expectations and perceptions vary geographically across country groups in Table 4. Panel A of Table 4 focuses on inflation expectations as the outcome variable, while Panel B on inflation perceptions. When comparing each group of countries at a time with all others in the sample in columns (1)-(6) of either Panel, we find that households in European and South American countries report, on average, 6.2pp (6.8pp) and 4.1pp (5.0pp) lower inflation expectations (perceptions) relative to the rest of the sample. While the systematic differences for average inflation expectations are still statistically significant in column (7) when the omitted category is Middle Eastern and African countries, their magnitudes shrink to about 3 and 2 pp, which is still economically large given average inflation expectations of 13.75% in the omitted category country group.

For inflation perceptions, we note a similar decrease in the estimated associations once we focus the comparison group to Middle Eastern and African countries. In this case, we cannot reject the null that the differences are statistically significant at plausible levels of significance.

Finally, respondents in high inflation countries perceive and expect inflation that is substantially higher than respondents in other countries by more than 15 pp for inflation expectations and 33 pp for perceptions.

3.3 The Transmission of Inflation Perceptions to Expectations

If respondents with the same inflation perceptions report systematically different expectations by demographic groups, demographic heterogeneity would extend beyond differences in the inputs to the belief-formation process to also affect the ways in which households form and

update their beliefs. If the mapping is instead similar across groups, differences in expected inflation are more likely to originate in differences in perceived inflation, which constitutes a central input into the updating process (Weber et al., 2023).

Figure 2 plots nonparametric estimates of expected inflation as a function of perceived inflation. We estimate the mapping separately by demographic groups: men and women, respondents with and without a college degree, respondents with high and low impatience, those who do and do not know their country’s central bank, those who do and do not understand the effect of inflation on nominal savings, and those with high and low trust in the central bank. To limit the influence of extreme responses, we winsorize all continuous variables observations between the 5th and 95th percentiles of the distribution of perceived inflation.

Two features of the figure stand out. First, perceived and expected inflation are strongly positively related for all groups. Respondents who perceive higher inflation over the previous 12 months also expect higher inflation over the subsequent 12 months. The mapping is approximately linear over the range in which most observations are concentrated but becomes noisier at high levels of perceived inflation. Thus, households update their expectations strongly in the direction of perceived inflation.

Second, the mapping from perceptions to expectations is remarkably similar across demographic groups. Within each panel, the two curves largely overlap throughout the central part of the distribution. This result is particularly notable for gender, impatience, and knowledge of inflation and central banks, because these characteristics are associated with economically large differences in the unconditional levels of perceptions and expectations. Conditional on reporting the same inflation perception, these groups update their expectations in nearly identical ways. The demographic gaps documented in Tables 2 and 3 therefore appear to arise primarily from differences in perceived inflation rather than from different updating rules.

Figure A.2 examines whether the same result holds across geographic and institutional environments. In parallel with the results we reported in Table 4, the upper panel of Figure A.2 estimates the mapping separately for Asia, the Middle East and Africa, Anglo-Saxon countries, South America, Europe, and countries experiencing very high inflation. Despite large

differences in actual inflation and in the levels of household beliefs across these groups, the mapping from perceptions to expectations is similar over most of the common support. The main departure occurs among European respondents who report very high perceived inflation. For these respondents, expectations respond less strongly to perceptions than in the other country groups. Because relatively few respondents lie in this part of the distribution, we interpret this upper-tail difference cautiously.

The lower panel considers a potential systematic role of different monetary policy frameworks on how perceptions map into beliefs, based on comparing, within the set of countries that engage in inflation targeting, those with point inflation targets and those with target ranges.⁴ The two mappings overlap closely, suggesting that households update inflation expectations in similar ways under the two frameworks. This comparison is descriptive because the design of inflation targets is correlated with other country characteristics. Nevertheless, the similarity is informative given the considerable variation in central banks and monetary policy frameworks represented in our sample.

Taken together, these findings indicate that the mapping from perceptions into expectations, and hence the updating of inflation beliefs conditional on perceptions, is similar across demographic groups and institutional environments. The principal source of heterogeneity in expected inflation appears to be what households believe inflation has recently been, rather than systematic differences in how they use these perceptions to update expectations. This result shifts attention toward the formation of inflation perceptions. We therefore turn next to the causal narratives households use to interpret recent inflation and examine whether these narratives vary across individuals and countries.

⁴We exclude countries whose central banks do not have an inflation targeting regime are excluded from this comparison, that is: Hong Kong SAR, Malaysia, Saudi Arabia, and Singapore.

4 Causal Narratives About Inflation: Heterogeneity Across Countries and Demographic Groups

Households do not observe aggregate inflation directly. Instead, they interpret the price changes they encounter in their daily life and organize them around causal accounts of why inflation has risen ([D’Acunto and Weber, 2025](#)). These narratives may shape which price changes households consider informative, whether they view inflation as temporary or persistent, and how they use recent inflation to update their expectations.

Understanding these causal accounts also connects our analysis to the debate over the sources of the post-pandemic inflation surge. The academic literature has assessed the relative importance of supply bottlenecks, commodity and energy prices, aggregate demand, labor-market tightness, and other forces in accounting for inflation ([Bernanke and Blanchard, 2025](#); [Shapiro, 2026](#)). At the same time, a growing literature shows that households rely on subjective models of the economy that often differ from those of experts and that these models affect how they interpret economic developments and information ([Andre et al., 2022, 2026](#); [D’Acunto et al., 2025](#)). Our survey allows us to study whether households’ causal accounts of inflation vary systematically across demographic groups and across countries with different economic histories and exposure to inflationary shocks.

The distinction between alternative inflation narratives is also relevant for monetary-policy practice. Whether inflation is attributed to supply disruptions, excessive demand, wages, firms’ profits, fiscal policy, or the central bank has implications for the persistence households attach to inflation and for the policies they believe can contain it. Central banks therefore face not only the task of communicating their inflation outlook and policy decisions, but also of explaining their diagnosis of the forces driving inflation ([Coibion et al., 2022](#); [Blinder et al., 2023](#)). Communication may be less effective when the public’s causal account differs from that of the central bank or when households attribute the inflation surge directly to monetary policy.

We first examine how inflation narratives vary with respondents’ demographic characteristics, economic knowledge, political alignment, and trust in the central bank. We then study geographic heterogeneity in narratives, which allows us to assess whether households’ causal accounts reflect differences in countries’ exposure to the post-pandemic shocks and their historical experience with inflation. These results also provide a bridge to the subsequent analysis. Narratives do not merely describe why households believe inflation occurred; they also assign responsibility and may therefore be related to the objectives households want central banks to pursue.

4.1 Demographic Correlates of Inflation Narratives

Understanding what households believe caused the post-pandemic inflation surge is important for assessing whether central bank communications are succeeding in shaping public understanding of inflation dynamics. Table 5 reports estimates from specifications of the following form:

$$\text{Cause of Inflation}_{i,c}^j = \alpha + \mathbf{X}_{i,c}'\delta + \varepsilon_{i,c}, \quad (2)$$

where $\text{Cause of Inflation}_{i,c}$ is a binary variable indicating whether respondent i in country c cites a given causal factor j for the post-pandemic inflation surge (respondents could select multiple causal factors), and $\mathbf{X}_{i,c}$ includes the same individual-level demographic variables we used in Table 2.

The results reveal systematic differences in causal attribution by age, gender, and respondents’ economic circumstances. A respondent who is 20 years older is 6 pp less likely to attribute inflation to the government and approximately 4 pp more likely to cite commodity prices and firms’ pursuit of higher profits. The same age difference is associated with a 6 pp increase in the probability of citing wars and geopolitical conflict. Women are 4.4 pp more likely than men to cite pandemic-related shortages and 2.9 pp more likely to cite commodity prices. Employment status is also relevant: unemployed respondents are 7 pp more likely to attribute inflation to the government and about 3 pp less likely to cite wages. These patterns

are consistent with the view that households' causal accounts reflect their personal circumstances and the economic shocks to which they pay attention, although the cross-sectional estimates do not identify the underlying mechanism.

Behavioral characteristics are associated with a different division between domestic policy explanations and external shocks. Respondents with high risk tolerance are 4.6 pp more likely to attribute inflation to the central bank and 4 pp more likely to cite wages, but 4.4 pp less likely to cite wars. Highly impatient respondents are 3.7 pp more likely to cite the government and 2.2 pp more likely to cite the central bank, while being 3.1 pp less likely to cite commodity prices. Thus, impatience is associated with greater emphasis on domestic policy institutions and less emphasis on an external cost shock. These correlations complement the earlier result that impatient respondents report higher inflation perceptions and expectations: the same respondents also appear more likely to interpret inflation through narratives that assign responsibility to domestic policymakers.

Political alignment produces some of the largest differences in the table. Respondents whose preferred party is part of the government are 11.3 pp less likely to attribute inflation to the government. At the same time, they are 6.1 pp more likely to cite wages, 3.2 pp more likely to cite the central bank, and 2.6 pp more likely to cite pandemic-related shortages. Political alignment is thus related not only to respondents' assessments of economic outcomes but also to how they allocate responsibility for those outcomes. It is consistent with evidence that partisan affiliation shapes reported economic beliefs and expectations (Coibion et al., 2020; Binder et al., 2024; Kuang et al., 2025, 2024). Because political support and inflation narratives are elicited contemporaneously, however, we cannot distinguish partisan attribution from the possibility that respondents' economic views influence their political preferences.

Knowledge of inflation and central banks is associated with greater emphasis on external and supply-related explanations. Respondents who know their country's central bank are 4 pp more likely to cite commodity prices and 2.8 pp more likely to cite pandemic-related shortages. Those who understand the effect of inflation on nominal savings are 3.9 pp more likely to cite commodity prices and 5.6 pp more likely to cite wars, while being 5.5 pp less likely to cite

wages. These findings do not imply that knowledgeable respondents necessarily hold the correct model of inflation. They show, however, that knowledge of inflation and monetary institutions is associated with a systematically different account of the post-pandemic inflation surge—one that places relatively greater weight on international and supply-side forces and holding views closer to those of macroeconomic experts on the importance of supply-side shocks (Dräger et al., 2025).

Trust in the central bank is associated with an especially pronounced reallocation of responsibility. Respondents with high trust in the central bank are 9.5 pp less likely to cite the government as a cause of inflation. They are 4.9 pp more likely to cite commodity prices, 3.8 pp more likely to cite pandemic-related shortages, 3.1 pp more likely to cite firms’ pursuit of higher profits, and 9.5 percentage points more likely to cite wages. Hence, respondents who trust the central bank are less likely to rely on a government-policy narrative and more likely to emphasize price-setting, labor-cost, and supply-side explanations. The direction of causality is ambiguous: trust may shape how households interpret inflation, but the narratives households adopt may also affect their trust in economic institutions.

Taken together, the results show that inflation narratives are systematically related to respondents’ economic circumstances, behavioral traits, political alignment, knowledge, and institutional trust. The largest differences are associated with political alignment and trust, suggesting that causal narratives reflect not only exposure to economic shocks but also how households assign responsibility across institutions and economic actors. These findings matter for monetary-policy communication because the same account of inflation may be interpreted differently depending on households’ prior knowledge, political views, and trust in policymakers. We next examine whether narratives also vary systematically across geographic regions and countries with different inflation histories.

4.2 Cross-Country Heterogeneity in Inflation Narratives

We next ask whether inflation narratives also differ across geographic and institutional environments. Such differences might arise because households were exposed to different drivers of the post-pandemic inflation surge, because similar shocks received different public attention across countries, or because historical inflation experiences shape how households assign responsibility for price increases. The global scope of our survey allows us to compare these narratives using the same elicitation method and during the same period.

Table 6 goes in this direction and examines how causal narratives about the post-pandemic inflation surge vary across geographic regions. The largest geographic difference concerns wars and geopolitical conflict. In the omitted group (Middle Eastern and African countries), 40.9% of respondents cite wars as a cause of the inflation surge. European respondents are 24.9 pp more likely to do so, implying a predicted share of approximately 66%. This difference is large both in absolute terms and relative to the omitted-group mean. It is consistent with the heightened salience of the Russian invasion of Ukraine and the associated energy-price shock in Europe (Dräger et al., 2025). European respondents are also 5.8 pp more likely to cite commodity prices, but 7.4 pp less likely to cite firms’ pursuit of higher profits and 4.2 pp less likely to attribute inflation to the central bank. Taken together, these estimates indicate that European households place greater weight on external and geopolitical explanations and less weight on explanations that assign responsibility to domestic institutions or firms.

The differences for Anglo-Saxon countries and Asian countries are more muted. Respondents in English-speaking countries are 9.8 pp less likely than those in the Middle East and Africa to cite commodity prices. This is a sizable difference relative to the omitted-group share of 65.6%, but we detect no statistically significant differences for the other narratives. Similarly, none of the coefficients for Asia and Oceania is statistically distinguishable from zero. Geographic heterogeneity is therefore not pervasive across all regions and all potential causes; it is concentrated in specific narratives and country groups.

South American respondents are 9.4 pp less likely to attribute inflation to the central bank

and 13.1 pp less likely to cite firms’ pursuit of higher profits. Relative to the omitted-group means of 26.7% and 52.3%, these estimates correspond to reductions of approximately one-third and one-quarter, respectively. The absence of stronger government or central-bank narratives in South America cautions against treating geographic location or a general history of inflation as sufficient to determine how households interpret the recent episode. The narratives associated with the post-pandemic inflation surge need not coincide with those households might use to explain earlier inflation episodes.

A different pattern emerges in the countries experiencing very high inflation at the time of the survey. Respondents in these countries are 11.1 pp more likely to attribute inflation to the central bank. Relative to the omitted-group mean of 26.7%, this coefficient represents an increase of more than 40%. At the same time, they are 14.5 pp less likely to cite commodity prices and, at the 10% significance level, 12.1 pp less likely to cite wages. Thus, households living under very high inflation place greater weight on monetary policy and less weight on external cost pressures. This pattern is consistent with monetary policy and central-bank credibility becoming more salient when inflation is both high and persistent, although the estimates do not establish whether respondents’ narratives accurately identify the underlying sources of inflation.

More broadly, the regional indicators explain substantially more of the variation in geopolitical narratives than in the other perceived causes of inflation: the adjusted R^2 is 0.060 for wars, compared with 0.022 or less in the remaining columns. Geography therefore appears especially important for narratives linked to shocks whose exposure and salience vary sharply across locations. By contrast, we detect no reliable regional differences in the tendency to attribute inflation to governments or pandemic-related shortages.

5 Desired Central Bank Mandates

The preceding section shows that households differ systematically in the causal narratives they use to explain inflation. These narratives also differ in the responsibility they assign to

central banks, governments, firms, and external shocks. This evidence raises a related question: which objectives do households want central banks to pursue? Respondents who differ in their diagnosis of inflation may also differ in the functions they assign to the central bank and in the outcomes against which they evaluate its performance. We do not interpret a possible relationship between narratives and mandate preferences causally, but the two sets of beliefs jointly characterize households' subjective views of the role of monetary institutions.

This question is relevant for ongoing academic and policy debates about the appropriate scope of central-bank objectives. Central banks have traditionally been associated with price stability and, depending on the institutional setting, employment, economic growth, exchange-rate stability, and financial stability. Since the global financial crisis, their role in financial-market stabilization, liquidity provision, and credit allocation has become more prominent (Buiter, 2014). More recently, policymakers and researchers have debated whether central banks should also account for climate risks, environmental objectives, and the distributional effects of their policies (Campiglio et al., 2018). These additional responsibilities might allow central banks to address important economic risks, but they can also blur the boundaries between monetary, financial, and fiscal policy.

The scope of the mandate is therefore closely connected to central-bank legitimacy and independence. Delegating a narrow and measurable objective to an independent institution is easier to justify than delegating a broad set of objectives that involve distributional choices and tradeoffs across groups. A widening gap between the objectives central banks pursue and those the public considers appropriate might weaken political support for independence and reduce trust in the institution (Buiter, 2014; Goodhart and Lastra, 2018). Conversely, a narrow formal mandate may also undermine trust when households expect the central bank to respond to outcomes that lie outside its assigned responsibilities. Household mandate preferences are therefore not merely views about institutional design; they may shape the criteria households use to assess central-bank performance.

Our survey is particularly suited to studying these issues because respondents face the same list of potential objectives when reporting both the objectives they believe their central bank

pursues and those they would like it to pursue. The list includes price stability, financial stability, exchange-rate stability, economic growth, environmental protection, inequality reduction, and the provision of credit to governments, banks, and households and firms. Respondents can select several objectives, allowing mandate preferences to be multidimensional rather than forcing respondents to identify a single priority. We first study how desired mandates vary across demographic groups and countries. We then construct a respondent-level measure of the distance between perceived and desired mandates and examine whether this mandate gap is associated with inflation expectations and trust in the central bank.

5.1 Demographic Correlates of Mandate Preferences

Table 7 presents estimates of how desired central bank mandates vary across demographic characteristics, using the specification:

$$\text{Wants Mandate}_{i,c}^j = \alpha + \mathbf{X}_{i,c}'\delta + \varepsilon_{i,c}, \quad (3)$$

where $\text{Wants Mandate}_{i,c}^j$ is a binary indicator for whether respondent i desires their central bank to pursue mandate j listed on top of each column. The desired mandates we elicited include price stability, financial stability, exchange rate stability, economic growth, achieving environmental goals, reducing economic inequality, providing credit to the government, providing credit to the central bank, and providing credit to private households. We provided the desired goals in randomized order to avoid a rank-order bias. The specification contains the individual characteristics used in the preceding analysis, which enter jointly in each specification. Standard errors are clustered at the country level. Because respondents could select several objectives, support for one objective does not imply opposition to another.

Age and gender are associated with different views about the appropriate scope of central-bank responsibilities. A respondent who is 20 years older is 6 pp more likely to support financial stability, 4 pp more likely to support exchange-rate stability, and 2 pp more likely to support economic growth as central-bank objectives. The same age difference is associated with 6

pp lower support for environmental goals, 4 pp lower support for inequality reduction, and 6 pp lower support for credit provision to households and firms. Older respondents therefore favor a role centered more closely on macroeconomic and financial stabilization and less on environmental, distributional, and household-credit objectives.

Women are 3.3 pp more likely than men to support environmental goals, 4.2 pp more likely to support inequality reduction, and 2.2 pp more likely to support credit provision to households and firms. At the same time, they are 2.2 pp less likely to favor exchange-rate stability and 2.3 pp less likely to favor credit provision to private banks. We find no meaningful gender differences in support for price stability, financial stability, or economic growth. Thus, the gender results do not indicate uniformly stronger support for a larger central-bank mandate. They point instead to differences in the types of additional objectives respondents consider appropriate.

Respondents' economic circumstances are particularly relevant for distributional and credit-related objectives. Unemployed respondents are 9.1 pp more likely to support inequality reduction, 5.9 pp more likely to support credit provision to households and firms, and 4 pp more likely to support economic growth. They are, however, less likely to favor credit provision to governments or private banks. The pattern therefore reflects support for objectives that directly concern household economic conditions rather than a general preference for central-bank credit allocation. Renters are approximately 3 pp more likely to support price stability, 2.5 pp more likely to support financial stability, and 3.9 pp more likely to support inequality reduction. By contrast, single respondents are less likely to support economic growth, inequality reduction, and credit provision to banks or households and firms.

Political alignment is also related to the desired boundary between monetary and fiscal responsibilities. Respondents whose preferred party is in government are 4.8 pp more likely to support central-bank credit provision to the government and 2.6 pp more likely to support credit provision to private banks. They are also 3.2 pp more likely to support environmental objectives. These associations suggest that views about central-bank responsibilities partly reflect the political environment in which those responsibilities would be exercised. Because

political alignment and mandate preferences are elicited contemporaneously, however, the estimates do not establish whether political support shapes institutional preferences or the reverse.

Behavioral characteristics reveal a different pattern. Respondents with high risk tolerance are 4.4 pp less likely to support price stability and 2.8 pp less likely to support financial stability. They are instead 4.5 pp more likely to support environmental objectives and between 3.4 and 5.2 pp more likely to support each form of credit provision. Higher risk tolerance is therefore associated with less emphasis on stabilization and a greater willingness to assign the central bank broader environmental and credit-allocation responsibilities.

High impatience is associated with lower support for each of the four conventional macroeconomic objectives. Highly impatient respondents are 4.3 pp less likely to support price stability, 4.8 pp less likely to support financial stability, 3.7 pp less likely to support exchange-rate stability, and 4.4 pp less likely to support economic growth. Importantly, impatience is not associated with greater support for environmental, distributional, or credit-related objectives. The results therefore do not suggest that impatient respondents prefer a broader mandate. Rather, they express weaker support for the conventional stabilization functions of central banks.

The largest and most systematic differences concern respondents' knowledge of inflation and central banks. Respondents who identify their country's central bank are 7.3 pp more likely to support price stability, 9 pp more likely to support financial stability, 9.1 pp more likely to support exchange-rate stability, and 4.8 pp more likely to support economic growth. They are also 4.4 pp less likely to support environmental objectives, 2.8 pp less likely to support credit provision to governments, and 5 pp less likely to support credit provision to households and firms.

Respondents who understand the effect of inflation on nominal savings display a similar pattern. They are between 5.4 and 7.9 pp more likely to support each of the four conventional objectives and between 3.6 and 4.4 pp less likely to support the three credit-provision objectives. The similarity of the two sets of estimates is notable because the measures capture distinct forms of knowledge. Awareness of the monetary institution and an understanding

of inflation are both associated with preferences that more closely resemble the conventional functions assigned to central banks. These associations need not be causal: respondents who favor traditional mandates may also be more likely to acquire information about monetary policy.

Trust in the central bank is related to mandate preferences in a different way. Respondents with high trust are 6 pp more likely to support exchange-rate stability, but they are also 7.2 pp more likely to support environmental objectives, 10 pp more likely to support credit provision to the government, and 10.7 pp more likely to support credit provision to private banks. High trust is not significantly associated with support for price or financial stability. Thus, trust does not simply align households with a narrow or conventional mandate. Instead, respondents who trust the central bank appear more willing to delegate a broader set of responsibilities to it. The direction of this relationship is ambiguous: trust may increase willingness to expand the central bank's role, while agreement with the institution's perceived role may itself foster trust.

Taken together, the results reveal several distinct dimensions of mandate preferences. Knowledge of inflation and central banks is associated with stronger support for conventional stabilization objectives and less support for credit allocation. Economic circumstances are related primarily to distributional and household-oriented objectives, while risk tolerance is associated with broader environmental and credit responsibilities. Trust, in turn, is associated with a greater willingness to delegate several additional functions to the central bank. We next study whether desired objectives also vary across geographic and institutional environments.

5.2 Cross-Country Heterogeneity in Mandate Preferences

The preceding subsection documents substantial heterogeneity in desired central-bank objectives across individuals. We next ask whether mandate preferences also vary systematically across geographic and inflation environments. Such differences might reflect variation in the legal responsibilities of central banks, countries' historical experience with inflation and financial

instability, and the extent to which monetary authorities have been involved in exchange-rate management, credit allocation, or broader policy objectives.

Table 8 examines desired mandates across country groups with respondents in the Middle East and Africa constitute the omitted group. Because respondents could select several objectives, the coefficients measure percentage-point differences in support for each objective and need not sum to zero across columns.

A first result is the broad agreement about the core functions of central banks. In the omitted group, 69.5% of respondents support price stability and 72.2% support financial stability. Support for these objectives differs little across most country groups. The only statistically significant difference is that respondents in Asia and Oceania are 6.3 pp less likely to select price stability. Thus, geographic heterogeneity does not primarily concern whether central banks should pursue price and financial stability. It concerns which additional responsibilities households want to assign to them.

The differences are particularly pronounced in Europe. Relative to respondents in the Middle East and Africa, European respondents are 16 pp less likely to support exchange-rate stability and 19.1 pp less likely to support economic growth as central-bank objectives. These estimates imply predicted support rates of approximately 49% and 56%, compared with 65% and 75% in the omitted group. European respondents are also 11.2 pp less likely to support environmental objectives and 11 pp less likely to support inequality reduction. The largest proportional differences concern credit allocation: Europeans are 16.6 pp less likely to support credit provision to private banks and 15.4 pp less likely to support credit provision to households and firms. Relative to the omitted-group means of 32.3% and 41.6%, these estimates represent reductions of approximately one-half and one-third, respectively.

Respondents in English-speaking countries display a related but less pronounced pattern. They are 9.5 pp less likely to favor exchange-rate stability, 10.6 pp less likely to favor environmental objectives, and 12.8 pp less likely to support credit provision to households and firms. Support for price stability, financial stability, and economic growth, however, is not statistically different from the omitted group. Respondents in Asia and Oceania differ reliably

only in their lower support for price stability and environmental objectives. Hence, the results do not support a uniform advanced-economy model of desired central-bank responsibilities. The relevant differences depend on the specific objective and region.

South American respondents express especially limited support for central-bank credit provision to other public and financial institutions. They are 18.5 pp less likely to support credit provision to the government and 19.4 pp less likely to support credit provision to private banks. Relative to the omitted-group means, these estimates correspond to reductions of almost 60%. By contrast, their support for economic growth, inequality reduction, and credit provision to households and firms does not differ significantly from that of respondents in the Middle East and Africa. South American respondents therefore do not uniformly favor either a narrower or a broader central-bank mandate. Rather, they distinguish sharply between support directed toward governments and banks and objectives directed toward growth, inequality, or households.

A similar pattern emerges in countries experiencing very high inflation. Respondents in these countries are 15.8 pp less likely to support credit provision to the government and 15.5 pp less likely to support credit provision to private banks. They are also 12.8 pp less likely to support environmental objectives and, at the 10% level, 8.3 pp less likely to favor exchange-rate stability. At the same time, their support for price stability, financial stability, economic growth, inequality reduction, and household credit does not differ significantly from the omitted group. Thus, high current inflation is not associated with uniformly stronger demand for a narrow price-stability mandate. It is instead associated with less willingness to assign selected environmental and credit-allocation responsibilities to the central bank.

Taken together, the results reveal a common core of support for price and financial stability alongside substantial geographic differences in the desired scope of central-bank responsibilities. These differences are concentrated in exchange-rate management, environmental objectives, and the provision of credit, rather than in the traditional price- and financial-stability functions. The evidence therefore does not admit a simple advanced-versus-emerging-economy interpretation. Historical experience, institutional arrangements, and the identity of the in-

tended beneficiary appear to matter for which additional objectives households regard as appropriate for central banks.

Country-group averages, however, do not reveal whether households believe their own central bank currently pursues the objectives they consider appropriate. Two respondents may prefer the same set of objectives but differ sharply in whether they perceive the central bank as following them. We therefore turn next to the respondent-level gap between perceived and desired objectives and examine how this gap relates to inflation expectations and trust in the central bank.

5.3 Mandate Preference Gaps, Expectations, and Trust in Central Banks

The preceding results document substantial heterogeneity in the objectives households want central banks to pursue. Such heterogeneity does not necessarily imply dissatisfaction with monetary institutions. What should matter for households' assessments of the central bank is whether the objectives they want it to pursue coincide with the objectives they believe it currently pursues. A respondent may favor a broad mandate and perceive the central bank as pursuing one, or favor a narrow mandate and perceive the institution as operating within that boundary. In either case, desired and perceived objectives are aligned. By contrast, disagreement arises when households believe that the central bank neglects objectives they consider important or pursues objectives they do not regard as appropriate.

We test this hypothesis by estimating specifications that regress respondents' trust in their central bank on the first principal component of the gap between the desired and perceived level of each mandate we asked about at the respondent level, plus the demographic characteristics we have used in all specifications that assessed demographic differences as well as country fixed effects. We find that a one-standard deviation increase in the first principal component, which captures a larger divergence between a respondent's desired and perceived mandates of their central bank, is associated with about 0.15 lower trust in their central bank (p-value<0.01),

which is about 6% of the average level of trust (2.5).⁵

These results are consistent with the idea that households evaluate central banks partly against the objectives they believe the institutions should pursue. When perceived and desired objectives diverge, respondents may regard the central bank as less representative of their priorities or less successful in addressing the outcomes they consider important. Lower trust may, in turn, reduce the weight households place on the central bank’s commitment to price stability and its communication about future inflation (Blinder, 2000; Christelis et al., 2020).

In fact, we would be even more interested in the gap between households’ desired and perceived central-bank mandates if this gap might help explain the cross-section of inflation expectations above and beyond demographic and country-group-level characteristics, on top of trust in central banks. In a specification similar to the above in which we replace trust in the central bank with numerical inflation expectations, we find that it does: a one-standard deviation increase in the first principal component of the gap between the desired and perceived level of each mandate is associated with about 0.62% higher inflation expectations (p-value<0.05), which is about 5% of the average level of inflation expectations (11.7%).

Taken together, the evidence shows that mandate preferences are related to economically relevant beliefs about monetary institutions. The issue is not simply whether households support narrow or broad central-bank responsibilities. What matters is the alignment between the objectives households want and those they believe their central bank pursues. Greater disagreement is associated with lower trust and higher inflation expectations, even among respondents facing the same national monetary-policy environment. These results suggest that central-bank credibility depends not only on policy outcomes and communication, but also on whether the public regards the scope of the institution’s responsibilities as appropriate.

⁵We do not tabulate the estimated coefficients for this specification, because it is a single regression. For those interested in the estimated coefficients attached to demographic characteristics we will share them upon request.

6 Conclusions

Using a global household survey conducted across 32 countries in March and April 2025, we assess the common drivers of inflation expectations, perceptions, and trust in central banks around the world. Our analysis yields four main conclusions.

First, the demographic determinants of inflation expectations and perceptions are global regularities: older individuals, men, the financially literate, and those who know the name of their central bank consistently report lower inflation expectations and perceptions, while unemployed and impatient individuals report higher values. The magnitudes of these effects are similar across widely different institutional environments.

Second, the transmission of inflation perceptions to expectations is stable across demographic groups and geographic regions. Whether comparing men and women, educated and less-educated respondents, or households in Europe and Latin America, the slope of the relationship between perceived past inflation and expected future inflation is essentially the same. This result beget further research into understanding what drives the systematic differences in inflation perceptions across demographics to understand differences in expectations, rather than focusing on potential heterogeneity in the expectations formation process across demographic groups.

Third, households differ systematically across regions in the causal narratives they attach to the recent inflation surge. European households emphasize geopolitical supply shocks; Latin American and high-inflation-country households emphasize domestic monetary and fiscal causes; Anglo-Saxon households are less likely to emphasize commodity prices. These differences are not mere noise—they reflect the differential salience of supply- and demand-side inflation drivers in different historical and institutional environments, and they have implications for how monetary policy communication should be framed in each context.

Fourth, desired central bank mandates vary across regions and demographic groups, and the gap between what households desire and what they perceive their central bank as doing is an important and understudied channel through which institutional trust can be eroded.

Moreover, the higher is this gap, the higher are households' inflation expectations. Financial literacy and central bank awareness are strongly associated with both narrower mandate gaps and higher institutional trust.

Taken together, these findings suggest that while the mechanisms of inflation expectation formation are broadly universal, the inputs to those mechanisms vary systematically across regions and demographic groups. Effective monetary policy communication must be tailored to these local institutional environments rather than derived from universal benchmarks calibrated to the experience of advanced economies.

Another important avenue for future research is to test whether the heterogeneity in causal narratives and mandate perceptions we document translates into heterogeneous economic choices, such as consumption, saving, portfolio allocation, which alter the real effects of monetary policy. Our survey does not include these outcome variables, but linking belief heterogeneity to behavior in a global context is an important and feasible next step.

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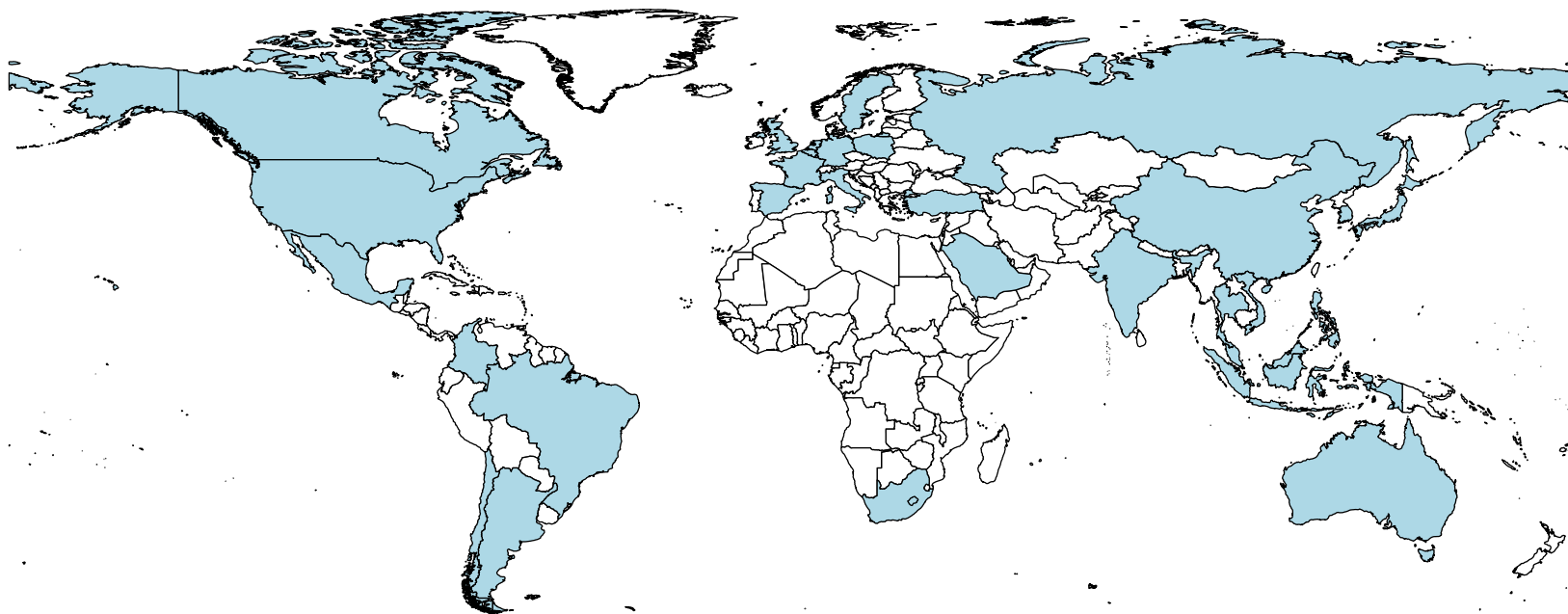
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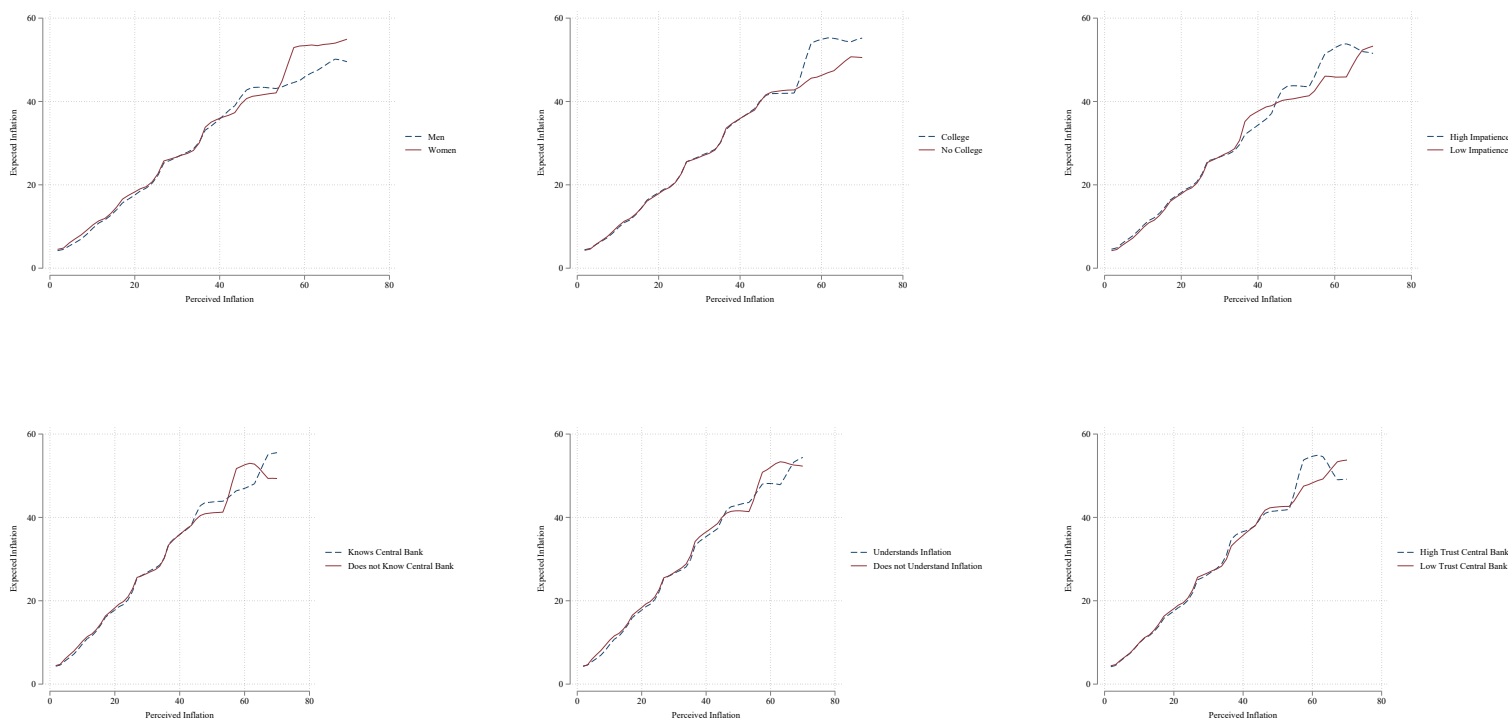
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Figure 1: Countries in the Sample



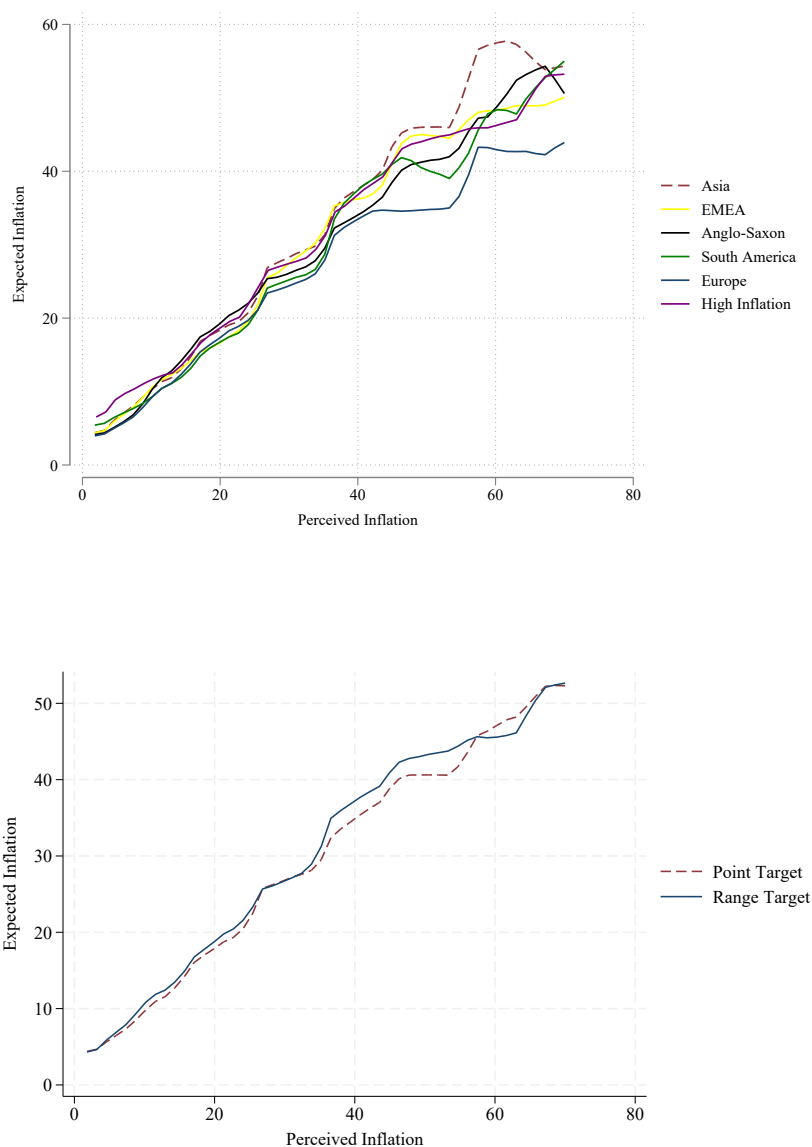
Notes: The data are from the *Global Survey of Economic Perceptions and Expectations* conducted in April-May 2025

Figure 2: Similar Transmission of Inflation Perceptions to Expectations by Demographics



Notes: The figure plots non-parametric estimates of the conditional mean of inflation expectations as a function of inflation perceptions, estimated separately for six pairs of demographic subgroups for which we detected universal differences in inflation perceptions and expectations: men versus women, college-educated versus non-college-educated, high-impatience versus low-impatience, those who know versus do not know their central bank, those who understand versus do not understand the effects of inflation on nominal savings, and those with high versus low trust in the central bank. The estimates are computed using local polynomial regressions on the support of perceived inflation within the 5th and 95th percentiles. The data are from the *Global Survey of Economic Perceptions and Expectations* conducted in April-May 2025

Figure 3: Similar Transmission of Inflation Perceptions to Expectations by Country Groups



Notes: The figure plots non-parametric estimates of the conditional mean of inflation expectations as a function of inflation perceptions, estimated separately for separate groups of countries by geographic and institutional groupings. The upper panel plots the pass-through separately for six regional groups: Asia and Oceania, the Middle East and Africa (EMEA), Anglo-Saxon countries, South America, Europe, and high-inflation countries (those with very high inflation levels at the time of our survey). The lower panel compares countries with point inflation targets against those with range targets. The estimates are computed using local polynomial regressions on the support of perceived inflation within the 5th and 95th percentiles. The data are from the *Global Survey of Economic Perceptions and Expectations* conducted in April-May 2025

Table 1: Summary Statistics

	Observations	Mean	St. Dev.	25 th	Median	75 th
Inflation Expectations	32,462	15.06	19.78	4	9	15
Inflation Perceptions	32,462	16.72	22.75	4	10	20
Rounded 5%	32,462	.08	.28	0	0	0
Rounded 10%	32,462	.13	.33	0	0	0
Affordability [1-4]	32,462	2.59	1.20	2	2	3
Expect Higher Interest Rate	32,462	.19	.74	0	0	1
Expect Higher Unemployment	32,462	.26	.73	0	0	1
Expect Higher Income	32,462	.26	.65	0	0	1
Age	32,462	40.94	13.98	30	40	52
Female	32,462	.49	.50	0	0	1
Knows Central Bank	32,462	.60	.49	0	1	1
Knows Inflation	27,653	.64	.48	0	1	1
Risk Tolerance [1-5]	31,726	3.09	1.44	2	4	4
Math Literacy [1-5]	31,920	3.70	1.28	2	4	5
Impatience [1-5]	31,907	2.84	1.43	2	2	4
Above Median Country Income	32,462	0.49	0.50	0.00	0.00	1.00
Preferred Party in Power	28,158	.56	.50	0	1	1
Trust Central Bank [1-4]	32,462	2.72	0.95	2	3	3
Trust Government [1-4]	32,462	2.51	1.04	2	3	3
Trust Banks [1-4]	32,462	2.62	0.93	2	3	3

Notes: This table reports summary statistics from the second wave of the Global Survey of Economic Perceptions and Expectations run in April and May 2025 and described in section 2.

Table 2: Demographics and Inflation Expectations Around the World

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)	(11)	(12)	(13)	(14)
Age	-0.143*** (0.03)													-0.102*** (0.03)
Female		2.677*** (0.56)												2.577*** (0.83)
Above Median Country Income			-0.741 (0.75)											0.495 (1.10)
College				-0.296 (0.65)										-0.300 (0.61)
Renter					0.611 (0.84)									-0.042 (0.80)
Unemployed						2.391*** (0.76)								1.853* (1.07)
Single							-2.536** (1.05)							-1.889* (0.99)
High Risk Tolerance								1.133 (0.93)						1.561 (0.96)
High Impatience									3.267*** (1.01)					2.954*** (0.95)
Pref Party in Power										-2.665 (2.22)				-3.103 (2.24)
Knows Central Bank											-3.072*** (0.90)			-2.316** (0.91)
Knows Inflation												-3.138** (1.28)		-3.033** (1.18)
High Trust Central Bank													-1.908 (1.68)	-1.638 (1.42)
Constant	20.933*** (2.50)	13.735*** (1.83)	13.938*** (2.60)	15.179*** (1.74)	14.910*** (1.68)	14.916*** (1.79)	15.409*** (1.87)	14.471*** (1.64)	13.633*** (1.43)	16.908*** (2.97)	16.908*** (1.98)	17.078*** (2.00)	15.489*** (2.11)	18.397*** (3.13)
Observations	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462	27,635	32,462	32,462	32,462	28,158	32,462	32,462	32,462	27,653	24,787
Adjusted R^2	0.010	0.005	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.001	0.002	0.001	0.007	0.004	0.006	0.006	0.002	0.040

Notes: We estimate specifications of the following form:

$$Inflation\ Expectations_{i,c} = \alpha + X'_{i,c}\delta + \epsilon_{i,c},$$

where $Inflation\ Expectations_{i,c}$ are the 12-month-ahead numerical inflation expectations reported by respondent i in country c ; $X'_{i,c}$ includes the set of demographic variables listed on the left column; Standard errors clustered at the country level are reported in parentheses. *p<0.10, **p<0.05, ***p<0.01

Table 3: Demographics and Inflation Perceptions Around the World

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)	(11)	(12)	(13)	(14)
Age	-0.145*** (0.04)													-0.100*** (0.03)
Female		2.311*** (0.71)												2.179** (0.90)
Above Median Country Income			0.268 (0.43)											0.638 (1.18)
College				-0.512 (0.92)										-0.475 (0.81)
Renter					0.116 (0.95)									-0.509 (0.94)
Unemployed						2.197*** (0.79)								1.984 (1.35)
Single							-2.676** (1.29)							-1.670 (1.28)
High Risk Tolerance								1.719* (0.98)						2.061* (1.06)
High Impatience									3.939*** (1.15)					3.777*** (1.06)
Pref Party in Power										-1.867 (2.34)				-2.452 (2.38)
Knows Central Bank											-3.995*** (1.08)			-3.549*** (1.03)
Knows Inflation												-3.673** (1.56)		-3.337** (1.04)
High Trust Central Bank													-1.632 (2.00)	-1.500 (1.77)
Constant	22.634*** (3.03)	15.573*** (2.36)	13.538*** (4.13)	16.922*** (2.21)	16.688*** (2.14)	16.583*** (2.24)	17.084*** (2.36)	15.822*** (2.08)	14.996*** (1.82)	17.765*** (3.45)	19.119*** (2.45)	19.169*** (2.31)	17.083*** (2.64)	23.252*** (3.47)
Observations	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462	27,653	32,462	32,462	32,462	28,158	32,462	32,462	27,653	32,462	24,787
Adjusted R^2	0.008	0.003	0.001	0.000	-0.000	0.000	0.002	0.001	0.007	0.002	0.007	0.006	0.001	0.037

Notes: We estimate specifications of the following form:

$$Inflation\ Perceptions_{i,c} = \alpha + X'_{i,c}\delta + \epsilon_i, c,$$

where $Inflation\ Perceptions_{i,c}$ are the numerical inflation perceptions for the 12 months before the interview reported by respondent i in country c ; $X'_{i,c}$ includes the set of demographic variables listed on the left column; Standard errors clustered at the country level are reported in parentheses. *p<0.10, **p<0.05,

***p<0.01

Table 4: Inflation Expectations and Perceptions by Country Groups

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
Inflation Expectations							
Europe	-6.163** (2.41)						-3.133** (1.36)
Anglo-Saxon		-2.955 (2.33)					-1.276 (1.74)
Asia			-0.932 (2.85)				0.705 (1.64)
South America				-4.125** (2.01)			-2.413* (1.37)
Emea					-1.403 (2.30)		—
High Inflation						25.765** (11.20)	24.640** (11.26)
Constant	16.776***	15.424***	15.382***	15.458***	15.148***	12.621***	13.745***
Observations	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462
Adjusted R^2	0.019	0.002	0.000	0.004	0.000	0.145	0.152
Inflation Perceptions							
Europe	-6.788** (3.06)						-3.083 (2.27)
Anglo-Saxon		-4.082 (2.81)					-1.764 (2.51)
Asia			-2.494 (3.53)				0.182 (2.45)
South America				-4.953* (2.67)			-2.660 (2.43)
Emea					-1.937 (3.24)		—
High Inflation						33.970** (13.32)	32.569** (13.48)
Constant	18.605*** (3.00)	17.218*** (2.54)	17.577*** (3.36)	17.193*** (2.46)	16.838*** (2.38)	13.499*** (0.59)	14.900*** (2.19)
Observations	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462
Adjusted R^2	0.018	0.003	0.003	0.004	0.000	0.191	0.195

Notes: We estimate specifications of the following form:

$$Inflation\ Expectations_{i,c} = \alpha + X'_{i,c}\delta + \epsilon_{i,c},$$

where $Inflation\ Expectations_{i,c}$ are the 12-month-ahead numerical inflation expectations reported by respondent i in country c ; $X'_{i,c}$ includes the set of demographic variables listed on the left column; Standard errors clustered at the country level are reported in parentheses. *p<0.10, **p<0.05, ***p<0.01

Table 5: Demographics and Perceived Causes of Inflation Around the World

	(1) Government	(2) Central Bank	(3) Commodity Prices	(4) Firms' Greed	(5) Pandemic	(6) Wars	(7) Wages
Age	-0.002*** (0.00)	-0.000 (0.00)	0.002*** (0.00)	0.002*** (0.00)	-0.000 (0.00)	0.003*** (0.00)	-0.000 (0.00)
Female	0.021** (0.01)	0.001 (0.01)	0.030*** (0.01)	-0.003 (0.01)	0.044*** (0.01)	0.001 (0.01)	-0.012 (0.01)
Above Median	-0.030** (0.01)	-0.006 (0.01)	0.019** (0.01)	0.004 (0.01)	0.024*** (0.01)	0.036*** (0.01)	-0.014* (0.01)
Country Income	-0.037** (0.02)	-0.002 (0.01)	0.010 (0.01)	-0.000 (0.01)	-0.004 (0.01)	-0.035* (0.02)	0.000 (0.02)
College	0.004 (0.02)	-0.034** (0.01)	0.002 (0.02)	0.012 (0.01)	0.024* (0.01)	0.032 (0.02)	-0.038** (0.02)
Renter	0.060*** (0.02)	-0.028* (0.02)	-0.013 (0.02)	0.019 (0.02)	-0.002 (0.02)	0.002 (0.03)	-0.033** (0.01)
Unemployed	-0.052*** (0.02)	-0.023* (0.01)	-0.014 (0.02)	-0.017 (0.02)	0.015 (0.02)	0.053*** (0.02)	-0.011 (0.02)
Single	0.036** (0.01)	0.048*** (0.01)	-0.011 (0.02)	-0.001 (0.01)	0.005 (0.01)	-0.051*** (0.02)	0.042*** (0.01)
High Risk	0.035*** (0.01)	0.022** (0.01)	-0.032*** (0.01)	0.002 (0.01)	-0.014 (0.01)	0.010 (0.01)	0.006 (0.01)
Tolerance	-0.112*** (0.02)	0.032** (0.01)	0.005 (0.02)	0.020 (0.02)	0.028** (0.01)	-0.018 (0.01)	0.060*** (0.01)
High Impatience	-0.014 (0.02)	0.002 (0.01)	0.041* (0.02)	-0.010 (0.02)	0.031*** (0.01)	0.006 (0.02)	0.016 (0.01)
Pref Party in Power	-0.007 (0.02)	-0.017 (0.01)	0.038** (0.02)	0.003 (0.01)	0.004 (0.01)	0.053*** (0.02)	-0.054*** (0.01)
Knows Central Bank	-0.093*** (0.02)	0.023 (0.02)	0.050*** (0.02)	0.031** (0.01)	0.039** (0.02)	0.012 (0.02)	0.096*** (0.01)
Knows Inflation	0.700*** (0.04)	0.240*** (0.03)	0.485*** (0.05)	0.370*** (0.04)	0.487*** (0.02)	0.338*** (0.04)	0.251*** (0.03)
Constant							
Observations	24,787	24,787	24,787	24,787	24,787	24,787	24,787
Adjusted R^2	0.035	0.010	0.015	0.004	0.006	0.021	0.031

Notes: We estimate specifications of the following form:

$$Cause\ of\ Inflation_{i,c} = \alpha + X'_{i,c}\delta + \epsilon_{i,c},$$

where $Cause\ of\ Inflation_{i,c}$ is a dummy variable that equals 1 if respondent i in country c thinks that the potential cause of inflation indicated on top of each column was an important driver of inflation, and zero otherwise; $X'_{i,c}$ includes the set of demographic variables listed on the left column; Standard errors clustered at the country level are reported in parentheses.

*p<0.10, **p<0.05, ***p<0.01

Table 6: Perceived Causes of Inflation by Country Groups

	(1) Government	(2) Central Bank	(3) Commodity Prices	(4) Firms' Greed	(5) Pandemic	(6) Wars	(7) Wages
Europe	-0.112 (0.14)	-0.042*** (0.01)	0.058** (0.03)	-0.074** (0.03)	-0.025 (0.09)	0.249*** (0.05)	-0.058 (0.07)
Anglo-Saxon	0.042 (0.14)	0.009 (0.02)	-0.098*** (0.03)	0.000 (0.03)	0.056 (0.09)	0.000 (0.05)	-0.009 (0.06)
Asia	-0.063 (0.14)	-0.006 (0.03)	0.021 (0.05)	-0.074 (0.04)	0.026 (0.09)	-0.017 (0.05)	0.071 (0.06)
South America	0.088 (0.15)	-0.094*** (0.03)	-0.058 (0.10)	-0.131*** (0.04)	0.024 (0.09)	-0.097 (0.06)	-0.074 (0.07)
High Inflation	0.056 (0.18)	0.111*** (0.02)	-0.145** (0.07)	0.006 (0.04)	-0.157 (0.12)	0.041 (0.16)	-0.121* (0.07)
Constant	0.541*** (0.14)	0.267*** (0.01)	0.656*** (0.02)	0.523*** (0.02)	0.562*** (0.09)	0.409*** (0.04)	0.283*** (0.06)
Observations	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462
Adjusted R^2	0.020	0.012	0.020	0.007	0.013	0.060	0.022

Notes: We estimate specifications of the following form:

$$Cause\ of\ Inflation_{i,c} = \alpha + X'_{i,c}\delta + \epsilon_{i,c},$$

where $Cause\ of\ Inflation_{i,c}$ is a dummy variable that equals 1 if respondent i in country c thinks thought that the potential cause of inflation indicated on top of each column was an important driver of inflation, and zero otherwise; $X'_{i,c}$ includes dummies for the country groups reported in the left column to which the respondent belongs with EMEA as omitted category. Standard errors clustered at the country level are reported in parentheses. *p<0.10, **p<0.05, ***p<0.01

Table 7: Desired Central Bank Mandates by Demographics

	(1) Price Stab	(2) Fin Stab	(3) ExchRate Stab	(4) Growth	(5) Environment	(6) Inequality	(7) Credit: Gov't	(8) Credit: Banks	(9) Credit: HH
Age	0.001 (0.00)	0.003*** (0.00)	0.002*** (0.00)	0.001** (0.00)	-0.003*** (0.00)	-0.002*** (0.00)	0.000 (0.00)	0.000 (0.00)	-0.003*** (0.00)
Female	0.006 (0.01)	0.004 (0.01)	-0.022** (0.01)	-0.000 (0.01)	0.034*** (0.01)	0.041*** (0.01)	-0.012 (0.01)	-0.023*** (0.01)	0.021*** (0.01)
Above Median	0.022* (0.01)	0.029*** (0.01)	0.038*** (0.01)	0.022** (0.01)	0.003 (0.01)	-0.000 (0.01)	0.018** (0.01)	0.016** (0.01)	-0.015 (0.01)
Country Income	-0.010 (0.01)	0.007 (0.01)	0.020* (0.01)	0.005 (0.01)	-0.026*** (0.01)	-0.010 (0.01)	0.002 (0.01)	0.005 (0.01)	-0.029** (0.01)
College	0.031** (0.01)	0.024** (0.01)	0.004 (0.01)	0.005 (0.01)	-0.004 (0.01)	0.036** (0.02)	-0.003 (0.01)	-0.010 (0.01)	0.007 (0.02)
Renter	0.003 (0.01)	0.027* (0.02)	0.013 (0.02)	0.035** (0.02)	0.023 (0.02)	0.084*** (0.02)	-0.021* (0.01)	-0.020** (0.01)	0.052*** (0.02)
Unemployed	0.002 (0.01)	-0.003 (0.01)	-0.027* (0.01)	-0.047*** (0.02)	-0.014 (0.01)	-0.056*** (0.01)	-0.009 (0.01)	-0.037*** (0.01)	-0.061*** (0.02)
Single	-0.045*** (0.01)	-0.028*** (0.01)	0.016 (0.01)	0.018 (0.01)	0.044*** (0.01)	-0.004 (0.01)	0.033*** (0.01)	0.053*** (0.01)	0.037*** (0.01)
High Risk	-0.043*** (0.01)	-0.050*** (0.01)	-0.040*** (0.01)	-0.048*** (0.01)	-0.010 (0.01)	-0.012 (0.01)	0.005 (0.01)	-0.010 (0.01)	0.010 (0.01)
High Impatience	-0.015 (0.01)	-0.017 (0.01)	-0.001 (0.01)	0.009 (0.02)	0.030** (0.01)	-0.023 (0.02)	0.047*** (0.01)	0.028*** (0.01)	0.018* (0.01)
Pref Party in Power	0.074*** (0.02)	0.094*** (0.02)	0.098*** (0.02)	0.056*** (0.02)	-0.046*** (0.01)	0.014 (0.02)	-0.030*** (0.01)	0.007 (0.01)	-0.046*** (0.01)
Knows Central Bank	0.078*** (0.02)	0.073*** (0.01)	0.053*** (0.01)	0.073*** (0.01)	-0.035** (0.01)	0.025** (0.01)	-0.037*** (0.01)	-0.044*** (0.01)	-0.036*** (0.01)
Knows Inflation	0.016 (0.01)	0.009 (0.01)	0.064*** (0.01)	0.010 (0.02)	0.070*** (0.01)	-0.000 (0.02)	0.100*** (0.01)	0.108*** (0.01)	0.018 (0.02)
Hlgh Trust	0.577*** (0.03)	0.516*** (0.03)	0.405*** (0.03)	0.532*** (0.03)	0.410*** (0.02)	0.572*** (0.04)	0.181*** (0.02)	0.171*** (0.02)	0.450*** (0.03)
Constant	24,787	24,787	24,787	24,787	24,787	24,787	24,787	24,787	24,787
Observations	0.024	0.044	0.027	0.017	0.032	0.010	0.027	0.035	0.024
Adjusted R^2									

Notes: We estimate specifications of the following form:

$$Wants\ Mandate_{i,c} = \alpha + X'_{i,c}\delta + \epsilon_{i,c},$$

where $Wants\ Mandate_{i,c}$ is a dummy variable that equals 1 if respondent i in country c indicates that they would desire their country's central bank to pursue the mandate indicated on top of each column, and zero otherwise; $X'_{i,c}$ are the demographic characteristics indicated on the left column; Standard errors clustered at the country level are reported in parentheses. *p<0.10, **p<0.05, ***p<0.01

Table 8: Desired Central Bank Mandates by Country Groups

	(1) Price Stab	(2) Fin Stab	(3) ExchRate Stab	(4) Growth	(5) Environment	(6) Inequality	(7) Credit: Gov't	(8) Credit: Banks	(9) Credit: HH
Europe	-0.012 (0.03)	-0.029 (0.05)	-0.160*** (0.04)	-0.191*** (0.07)	-0.112*** (0.02)	-0.110* (0.06)	-0.117 (0.08)	-0.166*** (0.06)	-0.154** (0.07)
Anglo-Saxon	0.005 (0.03)	0.038 (0.05)	-0.095** (0.04)	-0.084 (0.06)	-0.106*** (0.02)	-0.090* (0.05)	-0.090 (0.08)	-0.117* (0.06)	-0.128** (0.06)
Asia	-0.063** (0.03)	-0.006 (0.05)	-0.015 (0.04)	-0.111 (0.07)	-0.106*** (0.04)	-0.075 (0.06)	-0.076 (0.09)	-0.063 (0.06)	-0.102 (0.06)
South America	-0.001 (0.04)	0.025 (0.05)	-0.071** (0.03)	0.016 (0.06)	-0.128*** (0.03)	0.046 (0.06)	-0.185** (0.08)	-0.194*** (0.06)	0.033 (0.06)
Hyperinflation	-0.011 (0.04)	0.014 (0.05)	-0.083* (0.05)	-0.017 (0.06)	-0.128*** (0.04)	-0.028 (0.07)	-0.158* (0.09)	-0.155** (0.06)	-0.066 (0.08)
Constant	0.695*** (0.02)	0.722*** (0.05)	0.649*** (0.03)	0.753*** (0.06)	0.397*** (0.01)	0.580*** (0.05)	0.321*** (0.08)	0.323*** (0.06)	0.416*** (0.06)
Observations	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462	32,462
Adjusted R^2	0.003	0.002	0.015	0.022	0.004	0.009	0.011	0.020	0.015

Notes: We estimate specifications of the following form:

$$Wants\ Mandate_{i,c} = \alpha + X'_{i,c}\delta + \epsilon_{i,c},$$

where $Wants\ Mandate_{i,c}$ is a dummy variable that equals 1 if respondent i in country c indicates that they would desire their country's central bank to pursue the mandate indicated on top of each column, and zero otherwise; $X'_{i,c}$ are dummy variables capturing the whether the respondent belongs to the country group indicated on the left column with EMEA as ommitted category; Standard errors clustered at the country level are reported in parentheses. *p<0.10, **p<0.05, ***p<0.01

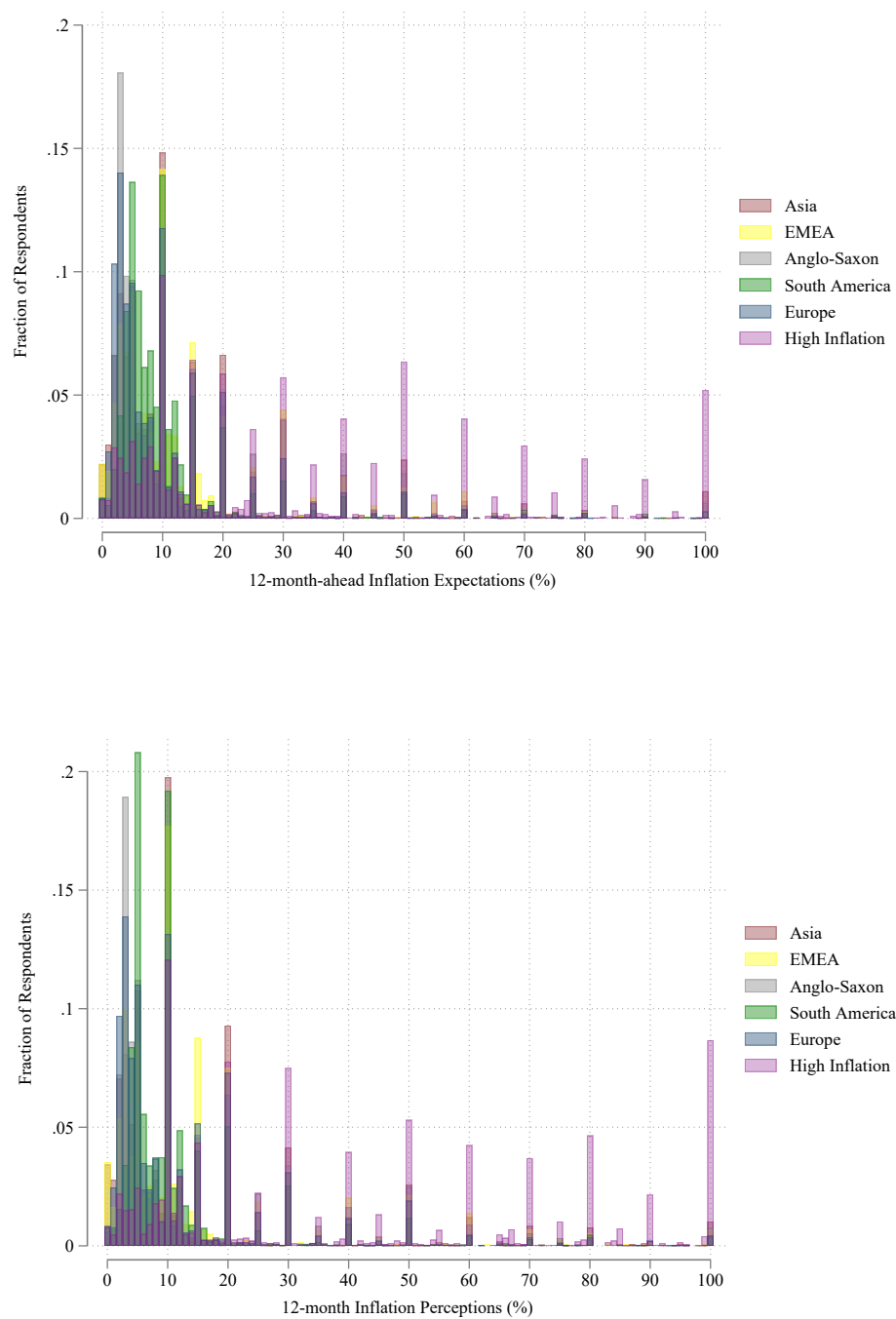
Online Appendix:

Inflation, Households, and Central Banks
Around the World

Francesco D'Acunto, Fiorella De Fiore, Damiano Sandri, and Michael Weber

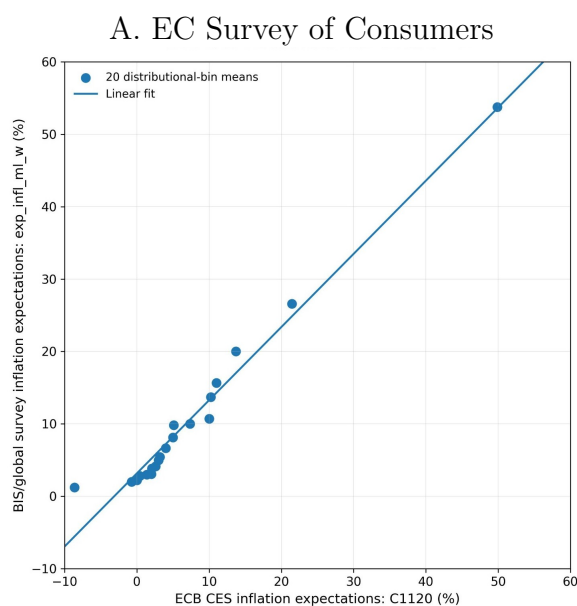
Not for Publication

Figure A.1: Inflation Expectations and Perceptions by Country Groups

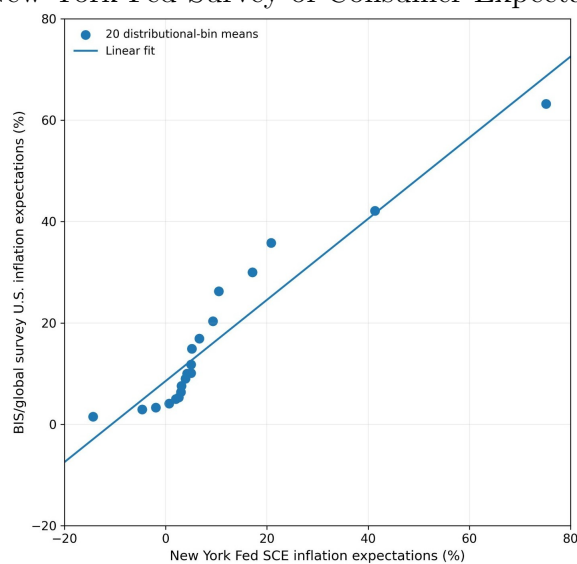


Notes: The data are from the *Global Survey of Economic Perceptions and Expectations* conducted in April-May 2025

Figure A.2: Comparison with EC Consumer Survey & NY Fed Survey of Consumer Expectations



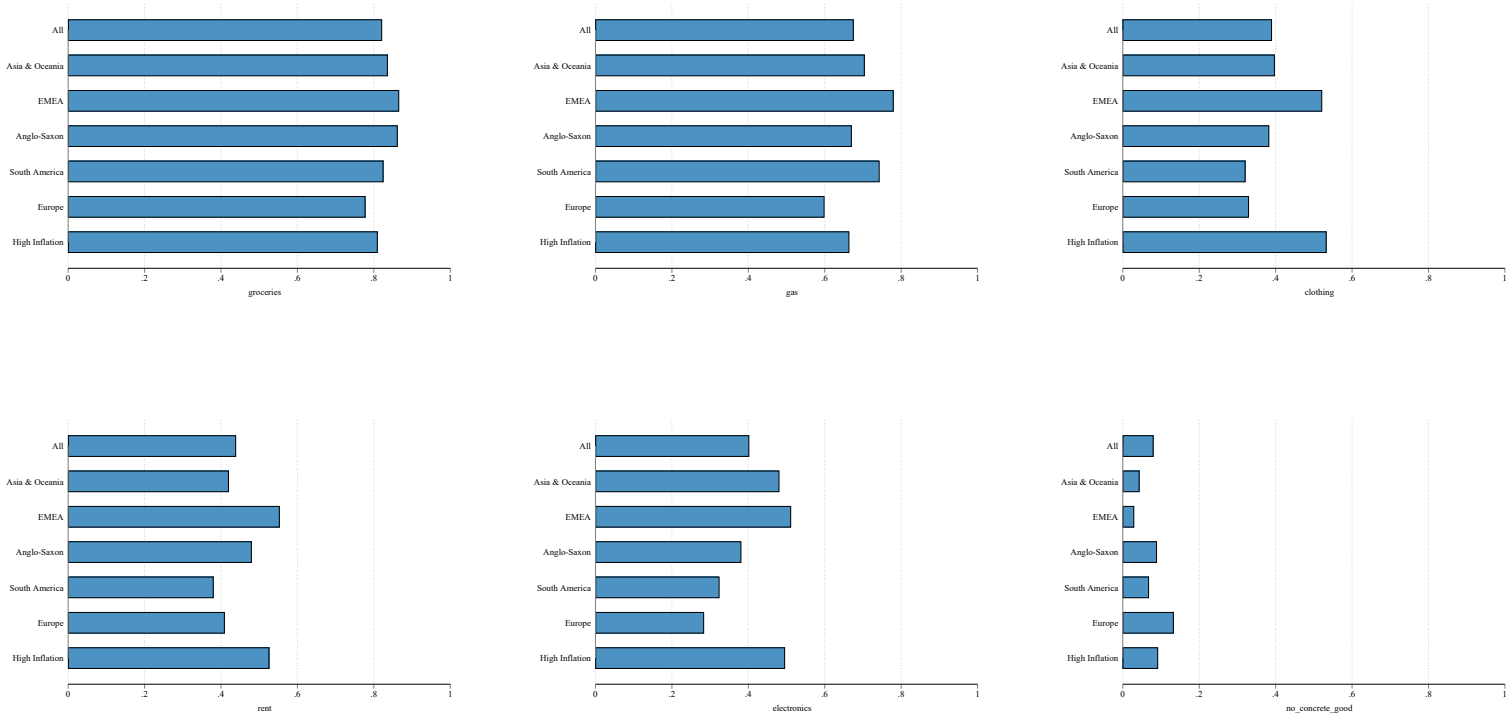
B. New York Fed Survey of Consumer Expectations



Notes: The figure plots quantile-quantile (Q-Q) plots comparing the empirical quantiles of the distribution of the variables indicated on top of each panel as elicited in the *Global Survey of Economic Perceptions and Expectations* conducted in April-May 2025 with the quantiles of the same variables as elicited at the household level in the European Commission Survey of Consumers (left pictures) and the New York Fed Survey of Consumer Expectations (right pictures). For the left pictures, in each survey we only include respondents from countries that overlap in the two surveys, that is: Spain, Belgium, Italy, France, Germany, and the Netherlands. For the right pictures, in each survey we only include respondents from the United States.

Figure A.3: Goods that Come to Mind when Forming Infation Expectations by Country Groups

IV



Notes: The data are from the *Global Survey of Economic Perceptions and Expectations* conducted in April-May 2025

Table A.1: Demographic Variables and Descriptions

Variable Name	Description
Age	Respondent’s age in years at time of survey; ranges from 18 to 70 years old.
Female	Dummy variable equal to 1 if respondent is female, 0 otherwise.
Above Median Country Income	Dummy variable equal to 1 if respondent’s gross income is above the median gross income of other] respondents in the country, 0 otherwise.
College	Dummy variable equal to 1 if respondent has completed an undergraduate degree or higher, 0 otherwise.
Renter	Dummy variable equal to 1 if respondent rents their primary residence, 0 otherwise.
Unemployed	Dummy variable equal to 1 if respondent is unemployed and actively looking for work, 0 otherwise.
Single	Dummy variable equal to 1 if respondent is single, 0 otherwise.
High Risk Tolerance	Dummy variable based on respondent’s self-assessed willingness to take financial risks, measured on a 5-point scale; equals 1 if respondent reports risk tolerance of 4 or 5, 0 otherwise.
High Impatience	Dummy variable based on respondent’s self-assessed impatience, measured on a 5-point scale; equals 1 if respondent reports impatience of 4 or 5, 0 otherwise.
Preferred Party in Power	Dummy variable equal to 1 if the political party closest to respondent’s views was part of their country’s government at the time of the survey, 0 otherwise.
Knows Central Bank	Dummy variable equal to 1 if respondent correctly identifies their country’s central bank from a randomized list of institutions, 0 otherwise.
Knows Inflation	Dummy variable equal to 1 if respondent correctly answers whether nominal savings returns raise purchasing power irrespective of inflation, 0 otherwise.
High Trust Central Bank	Dummy variable based on respondent’s trust in their country’s central bank, measured on a 4-point scale from “not at all” to “a lot”; equals 1 if respondent reports trust of 3 or 4, zero otherwise.

Notes: This table describes the demographic variables used in the analysis from the Global Survey of Economic Perceptions and Expectations conducted in March–April 2025.

Table A.2: **Country Groups**

Country Group	Countries (ISO Code)
Europe	Switzerland (CH), Belgium (BE), Germany (DE), Spain (ES), France (FR), Italy (IT), Netherlands (NL), Poland (PL), Sweden (SE)
Anglo-Saxon	Australia (AU), Canada (CA), United States (US), United Kingdom (GB)
Asia	China (CN), Indonesia (ID), India (IN), Malaysia (MY), Philippines (PH), Thailand (TH), Vietnam (VN), Hong Kong (HK), Japan (JP), South Korea (KR), Singapore (SG)
South America	Brazil (BR), Colombia (CO), Mexico (MX)
EMEA	Saudi Arabia (SA), South Africa (ZA)
High inflation	Argentina (AR), Russia (RU), Turkey (TR)

Notes: This table lists the country groups and their constituent countries identified by name and ISO country code used in the analysis.

Table A.3: Summary Statistics by Country Groups

	Observations	Mean	St. Dev.	Skewness	Kurtosis
Panel A: Europe					
Inflation Perceptions	9,035	11.82	14.93	3.26	16.62
Inflation Expectations	9,035	10.61	13.10	3.64	21.07
Panel B: Anglo-Saxon					
Inflation Perceptions	3,991	13.14	16.71	2.74	11.85
Inflation Expectations	3,991	12.47	15.35	2.92	13.98
Panel C: Asia					
Inflation Perceptions	11,200	15.08	19.64	2.78	11.60
Inflation Expectations	11,200	14.45	18.33	2.90	12.70
Panel D: EMEA					
Inflation Perceptions	2,035	14.90	17.70	2.78	12.22
Inflation Expectations	2,035	13.75	15.36	2.85	13.60
Panel E: South America					
Inflation Perceptions	3,127	12.24	15.80	4.25	24.39
Inflation Expectations	3,127	11.33	12.66	4.10	24.24
Panel F: High Inflation Countries					
Inflation Perceptions	3,074	47.47	38.98	0.60	1.97
Inflation Expectations	3,074	38.39	33.91	0.88	2.51

Notes: This table reports summary statistics from the second wave of the Global Survey of Economic Perceptions and Expectations run in April and May 2025 and described in section 2.

1 Survey Questions

Below we report the survey questions for the survey which was fielded in the U.S. The survey company translated this version to national languages. At the beginning, the survey started with a short introductory text. We also report some programming instructions that survey participants did not see.

Thank you very much for participating in this survey, which is expected to take about 8-10 minutes. This survey is designed to gather your views on economic issues. We are interested in your opinion, so there is no right or wrong answer. Even if you are unsure, please answer to the best of your knowledge. We would be grateful if you could complete the survey in a single session without distractions. We highly value your time and attention.

Question 1 *What is your age?*

[Integers from 0 to unbounded] KEEP ONLY PEOPLE BETWEEN 18 AND 70

Question 2 *What is your gender?*

- Male
- Female
- Prefer not to answer

Question 3 *In questionnaires like ours, sometimes there are participants who do not carefully read the questions and just quickly click through the survey. This means that there are many random answers which compromise the results of research studies. To show that you read our questions carefully, please choose that you are “very interested” in sports and “not interested at all” in music. [matrix structure]*

- How interested are you in sports?
- How interested are you in music?
- Not interested at all
- Not interested
- Interested
- Very Interested

KEEP ONLY PEOPLE THAT ANSWER: “very interested” IN SPORTS AND “not interested at all” IN MUSIC

We would like to ask you about the rate of inflation in your country. As you may know, inflation is the percentage change in overall prices in the economy. For example, if a price increases from 10 to 11, the rate of inflation is $(11-10)/10 = 10\%$. If a price decreases from 10 to 9, the rate of inflation is $(9-10)/10 = -10\%$. If a price does not change, the rate of inflation is 0%.

Question 4 *Over the **last** 12 months, what do you believe the rate of inflation has been in your country?*

[...] % [From -100 to unbounded. Up to 1 decimal point]

Question 5 *Now think about the possible rate of inflation in your country over the **next 12 months**. What do you expect could be the lowest, highest, and most likely value of inflation?*

- Lowest [...]
- Highest [...] [Error message: “Value must be higher than lowest value”]
- Most likely [...] [Error message: “Value must be between lowest and highest value”]

Question 6 *Thinking about your previous responses about the rate of inflation, were there any specific prices of goods that you had in mind when responding? Please select all that apply*

[randomize]

- Food / groceries
- Rent
- Gasoline / other energy prices
- Clothing
- Electronics / appliances
- Education
- Other
- No specific prices

[In Q7, Q8 and Q9, numerical field from 0 to unbounded, allow for 1 decimal]

Question 7 *Over the **next 12 months**, do you expect your **household income** to increase, decrease, or stay about the same?*

- Increase by about [...] %

- Decrease by about [...] %
- Stay about the same as today

Question 8 *Over the **next 12 months**, do you expect the **unemployment rate** in your country to increase, decrease, or stay about the same relative to the current level?*

- Increase by about [...] %
- Decrease by about [...] %
- Stay about the same as today

Question 10 *Over the **next 12 months**, do you expect **interest rates** in your country to increase, decrease, or stay about the same relative to current levels?*

- Increase by about [...] %
- Decrease by about [...] %
- Stay about the same as today

Question 11 *How much trust do you have in each of the following institutions to act in your best interest?*

[randomize, matrix structure]

- Your country's central bank [or "The central bank of the Euro Area"]
- Your country's government
- Your country's banks and financial institutions
- Not at all
- Not too much
- Some
- A lot

We would like now to learn about your perceptions of how prices and incomes in your country have changed over longer stretches of time in the past. Please provide your answers in percentage changes **over the entire period** indicated in the question. Regarding prices, please think about the cost of a consumption bundle that represents your everyday purchases such as energy, food, entertainment, housing, electronics, cloth, etc. For example, imagine this bundle costs 100 at the beginning of the period and its price increases to 120 at the end of the period. The percentage change is $(120-100)/100 = 20\%$. If average prices decrease from 100 to 80, the percentage change is $(80-100)/100 = -20\%$.

Question 12 *By how much do you think that **prices of consumption goods** in your country have changed over the following periods?*

- 2020-2024: [...] % [From -100 to unbounded. Up to 1 decimal point]
- 2015-2019: [...] % [From -100 to unbounded. Up to 1 decimal point]

Question 13 *Now think about changes in incomes of people like you, including wages and other sources of income. By how much do you think that incomes in your country have changed over following periods?*

- 2020-2024: [...] % [From -100 to unbounded. Up to 1 decimal point]
- 2015-2019: [...] % [From -100 to unbounded. Up to 1 decimal point]

Question 14 *Which of the following factors do you think have played an important role in the rise in **prices** between 2020 and 2024? Select all that apply.*

[randomize]

- The government
- The central bank
- Higher commodity prices
- Firms chasing higher profits
- Lack of goods caused by the pandemic
- Wars
- Higher wages

Question 15 *Which of the following factors do you think have played an important role in the rise of your **household income** between 2020 and 2024? Select all that apply.*

[randomize]

- Adjustment linked to the general price increase
- I worked very hard or invested wisely
- Government's support
- Central bank's support
- New tools to do my job

Question 16 *Do you think that today you can afford more or fewer goods and services than in 2020?*

- Way less
- Somewhat less
- About the same
- Somewhat more
- Way more

Question 17 *Do you know what the [name of the central bank] is?*

[randomize]

- One of the largest private banks
- The central bank
- A bank that provides services to the government
- An international financial institution
- A bank that provides services to the army

We would like to conclude the survey by asking you a few questions about the central bank of your country [or “the central bank of the Euro Area”].

Question 18 *Which of the following do you think are the **current goals** of the central bank in your country [or “the central bank of the Euro Area”]? Select all that apply.*

[randomize]

- maintain price stability
- Maintain financial stability
- Maintain exchange rate stability
- Promote economic growth
- Contribute to reaching environmental goals
- Contribute to reducing economic inequalities
- Provide credit to the government
- Provide credit to private banks
- Provide credit to households and firms

Question 19 *Now think about what you would like the central bank to do. Which of the following do you think **should be** the goals of the central bank? Select all that apply.*

[randomize]

- maintain price stability
- Maintain financial stability
- Maintain exchange rate stability
- Promote economic growth
- Contribute to reaching environmental goals
- Contribute to reducing economic inequalities
- Provide credit to the government
- Provide credit to private banks
- Provide credit to households and firms

Question 20 *In what ways do you think that the central bank tries to achieve its goals? Select all that apply.*

[randomize]

- Setting interest rates
- Imposing taxes on households and firms
- Imposing taxes on banks and financial institutions
- Extending credit to households and firms
- Extending credit to banks and financial institutions
- Announcing plans about its future decisions
- Purchasing or selling financial assets
- Printing money to finance the government
- Communicating the evolution of economic and financial conditions

Question 21 *Do you think that the central bank should operate independently of the government?*

[randomize]

- Yes, it should take decisions by itself
- No, it should act based on the government's goals and implement its policy

Question 22 *Which of the following sources do you use most to get information about the central bank and its policies? Select all that apply.*

[randomize]

- Newspapers
- Television or radio
- Social media
- Central bank's website
- Banks and financial advisors
- Friends, family, and co-workers

Question 23 *In your opinion, is this statement true or false:*

If the money in your savings account grows at an annual rate of 5%, then you will be able to buy more with this money in the future than you are able to buy today regardless of the rate of inflation.

- True
- False
- Don't know/No opinion

Question 24 *How often do you do the following activities in a typical month?*

- Shop for groceries [...] [Integer from 0 to 100]
- Buy gasoline [...] [Integer from 0 to 100]

Question 25 *How well, if at all, do the following sentences describe you as a person?*

[randomize, matrix structure]

- I am willing to take risks regarding financial matters
- I am good at math
- I am very impatient

- Not at all well
- Not too well
- Somewhat well
- Very well
- Don't know/No opinion

Question 26 *What is your household annual income before taxes?*

[...] name of local currency [Integers from 0 to unbounded]

Question 27 *Which of the following best characterizes your household?*

- Own my house/apartment without a mortgage/loan
- Own my house/apartment and have a fixed-rate mortgage/loan
- Own my house/apartment and have a variable-rate mortgage/loan
- Rent my house/apartment
- Other
- Don't know/ Prefer not to answer

Question 28 *How would you describe your present employment situation?*

- Job in the private sector
- Job in government
- Self-employed
- Not working and not looking for work
- Student
- Retired
- Unemployed, looking for work
- Prefer not to answer

Question 29 *Please tell us how many of people usually live in your primary residence other than yourself (including those who are temporarily away).*

- 1 person
- 2 people
- 3 people
- 4 people
- 5 or more people
- None

Question 30 *What is the highest level of education you have achieved?*

- Less than high school
- High school
- Some college but no degree (including academic, vocational, or occupational programs)
- Undergraduate degree (for example: BA, BS)
- Graduate or post-graduate degree (for example: MA, MS, PhD, MD, JD)

[If answered 4 or 5]

Do you have any degrees in business, finance, or economics?

- Yes
- No

Question 31 *Is the party that best aligns with your political views currently part of the government in your home country?*

- Yes
- No
- Prefer not to answer